
Audi Alteram Partem

Journal of Law, Science, and Society

ARTICLES

Routine Activity Theory: Its Origins, Applications, and Implications

Gretchen Weir

Nationalism and State-Building After the Collapse of the USSR

Judah Abusalah

A Country Under Control: An Analysis of Russia's Autocracy

Joseph Stachelek

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Sadana Saravanan

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Audi Alteram Partem: Journal of Law, Science, and Society is an interdisciplinary research journal dedicated to bridging the gap between law, science, and societal issues.

NOTE FROM THE FOUNDER & EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Dear Readers,

It is with immense pride and gratitude that I present the second issue of *Audi Alteram Partem: Journal of Law, Science, and Society*. When I founded this journal last semester, I imagined a space where rigorous scholarship, interdisciplinary curiosity, and a commitment to justice could coexist. Today, that vision becomes real.

“Audi Alteram Partem”—*hear the other side*—is more than a title; it is a principle that defines the work we aim to cultivate. In an era where legal questions increasingly intersect with rapid technological change, scientific innovation, and complex social challenges, our journal stands as an invitation to dialogue. We believe that meaningful progress requires voices from multiple disciplines, diverse lived experiences, and all corners of the academic community.

Our contributors, comprising students and emerging scholars from diverse fields, explore topics at the intersection of law, policy, science, ethics, and society. Their work demonstrates not only intellectual rigor but also a shared commitment to understanding the world more deeply and imagining how it might be improved.

I extend my sincere thanks to our executive board and mentors who believed in this project from its earliest moments. Launching a new journal is no small undertaking, and their dedication made the impossible feel attainable. I am equally grateful to our authors, who entrusted us with their ideas and helped set a high standard for future issues.

As you read this issue, I hope you find yourself challenged, inspired, and reminded of the value of interdisciplinary inquiry. This journal is just beginning, and I am excited for the conversations and the community that will grow as a result of our inaugural year.

Thank you for supporting us this year. We look forward to amplifying new voices, fostering thoughtful debate, and continuing to *hear the other side*.

Sincerely,

Kavya Ramkumar
Founder & Editor-in-Chief
Audi Alteram Partem: Journal of Law, Science, and Society

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Routine Activity Theory: Its Origins, Applications, and Implications.....	1
Gretchen Weir, Wayne State University	
Nationalism and State-Building After the Collapse of the USSR.....	15
Judah Abusalah, Wayne State University	
A Country Under Control: An Analysis of Russia’s Autocracy.....	26
Joseph Stachelek, Wayne State University	
Houthi Attacks in the Red Sea: The Role of Missiles and Drones.....	37
Judah Abusalah, Wayne State University	
The Fragile Progress of Organized Labor.....	44
Sara Poles, Wayne State University	
The Relationship Between Repeated Cyberbullying Exposure and Depression in High School Students.....	49
Sadana Saravanan, Wayne State University	
Influences of Politics on Irish and American Music.....	58
Amelia Hawkins, Wayne State University	

Routine Activity Theory:

Its Origins, Applications, and Implications

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Wayne State University

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I. Routine Activity Theory: Its Origins, Applications, and Implications

The large majority of traditional and modern criminological theories attempt to answer the same question: Why are individuals motivated to commit crime? For example, some criminologists posit that offenders go through a rational thought process, while others theorize that some people are biologically predisposed to crime. More modern theorists examine how social strain factors affect crime as well as the influence of power structures. Routine activity theory (RAT) is different, however, as it seeks to answer a different question: What situations create the opportunity for crime? The motivation of an offender is not relevant in RAT, but the circumstances under which a crime occurs are of utmost importance. Lawrence E. Cohen and Marcus Felson first introduced the theory in their 1979 article, “Social Change and Crime Rate Trends: A Routine Activity Approach,” in which they try to explain the rapid increase in crime in the 1960s and ‘70s using three factors: a motivated offender, a suitable target, and a lack of capable guardians. Without one of these factors, according to Cohen and Felson (1979), a crime cannot occur.

Since its introduction in the late 1970s, RAT’s simple but powerful ideas have opened doors for criminologists and policymakers. The theory has proven to be flexible, as it can explain a wide variety of crimes, whether it be burglary, sexual assault, or cybercrime. Its framework of three factors can be adapted to apply to different spaces (digital or physical), types of offenders, and crimes, which is relatively unique among criminological theories. For example, although RAT originally attempted to explain a macro-level increase in crime, criminologists have since applied the theory to micro-level situations, such as those surrounding stalking and cyberstalking. However, research about stalking and cyberstalking, especially as they relate to RAT, is sparse, and the theory often overlooks these crimes. Additionally, RAT has provided numerous ideas for unique crime prevention policies focusing on spaces rather than offenders, including practices for how spaces can be designed to reduce criminal opportunity.

With this in mind, this paper aims to provide an understanding of four different topics. First, I will discuss Cohen and Felson’s original 1979 theory, including the statistics they used to support their hypotheses. Next, due to the lack of research about RAT and stalking, I will apply RAT to the crime of stalking using a traditional version of the theory. I will then describe how the theory can be, and has been, altered to fit with more modern crimes. Specifically, I will examine how the three elements can apply to situations in which cybercrime occurs. Finally, I will provide an overview of RAT’s main implications, situational crime prevention, and crime prevention through environmental design. I will also explain how policies stemming from these techniques can help prevent stalking and cyberstalking. Overall, I hope to show the following: RAT remains one of the most flexible, adaptable, and significant criminological theories due to its wide applicability and its relevance in crime prevention policies.

II. The Original Theory

The underlying purpose of Cohen and Felson's (1979) article was to understand the factors behind the notorious increase in crime rates from 1960 to 1975. Cohen and Felson suggest that these increases were attributable to the changes in "routine activities" during this time (Cohen & Felson, 1979). They defined routine activities as "any recurrent and prevalent activities which provide for basic population and individual needs" (Cohen & Felson, 1979, p. 593). Such activities can be survival-related, such as finding food and shelter, or other activities that contribute to human life, such as work, school, social activities, leisure, or sex. The common denominator is that these activities take up a good portion of our everyday lives (Cohen & Felson, 1979).

Cohen and Felson examined the ways in which routine activities changed after World War II, specifically in the 1960s and '70s, arguing that routine activities largely shifted from at home to away from home during this period, which explained the rapidly rising crime rates (Cohen & Felson, 1979). The role of women in society, for example, has transformed dramatically. The proportion of female college students in the population more than doubled, and the contribution of married women to the labor force increased by thirty-one percent. Additionally, the number of vacations taken by Americans increased by eighty-one percent from 1967 to 1972. As a result, the proportion of American households that were unattended by an adult increased (up to fifty-eight percent) at all times during the day (U.S. Bureau of the Census, 1975, as cited in Cohen & Felson, 1979). To test their theory that these changing activities were related to the dramatic increase in crime, Cohen and Felson developed a "household activity ratio," which they derived from the data, suggesting more activities were taking place away from an individual's home. They found "positively and statistically significant relationships between the household activity ratio and each official crime rate change," allowing them to suggest that routine activities were, in fact, useful for explaining why crime took place (Cohen & Felson, 1979, p. 602). Cohen and Felson also noted that the relationship of the crime rates with the household activity ratio was stronger than that with the age structure of society, despite many theorists' belief that the rise in the young adult population was the main cause of the rise in crime (Cohen & Felson, 1979).

To further understand the foundation of the theory, one needs to ask *why* crime rates and household activities are related so closely. Cohen and Felson argued that such changes in the patterns of routine activities "can influence crime rates by affecting the convergence in space and time of the three minimal elements of...violations: (1) motivated offenders, (2) suitable targets, and (3) the absence of capable guardians against a violation" (Cohen & Felson, 1979, p. 589). This convergence is the core of RAT and is when crime is most likely to happen. Further, when even one of the three elements is absent, that is sufficient to prevent the completion of a crime (Cohen & Felson, 1979). To go more in-depth, Cohen and Felson defined a suitable target as an object or person with some kind of vulnerability that a motivated offender can take advantage of. Targets depend on value (the worth or desirability of the target), accessibility (ease of pursuing the target), physical visibility of the target, and inertia of a target (such as the inability to defend themselves, or the size, weight, or security of an object). Capable guardians, on the other hand,

are anything that can reduce the offender's ease of committing and getting away with a crime. Guardians can be law enforcement officers, security cameras, dogs in homes, the presence of crowds, car alarms, etc. (Cohen & Felson, 1979). With respect to reducing crime, suitable targets and the absence of capable guardians are the most significant elements, and changes in them can be effective in preventing offenders from carrying out crimes.

Cohen and Felson also applied RAT to the rise in specific crimes in the '60s and '70s, focusing on robbery, burglary, and larceny with emphasis on property and goods as suitable targets. They argued that the shift in routine activities provided "more suitable property available for theft" (Cohen & Felson, 1979, p. 599). During this period, automobile thefts were the most common type of theft at sixty-nine percent of all theft in 1975, along with home entertainment items, which were stolen four times more than any other home good (Federal Bureau of Investigation, 1976, as cited in Cohen & Felson, 1979). So, it is most relevant to examine these types of theft primarily. From 1960 to 1970, Americans spent significantly more money on automobiles and home goods like televisions and appliances (Council of Economic Advisors, 1976, as cited in Cohen & Felson, 1979; Electrical Merchandising Week, 1964; Merchandising Week, 1973, as cited in Cohen & Felson, 1979). Cohen and Felson (1979) attributed these statistics to the increase in the proportion of the population going to college and work, the increase in travel, and the spread of the population across more households, creating a much larger market for vehicles and home entertainment items. In addition to the expanding markets, "this same period appears to have spawned a revolution in small durable product design which further feeds the opportunity for crime to occur" (Cohen & Felson, 1979, p. 599). For instance, the lightest television for sale was thirty-eight pounds in 1960, but only fifteen pounds in 1970, making it more suitable as a target. As expected, daytime residential burglaries during this decade increased from sixteen to thirty-three percent of total burglaries (Cohen & Felson, 1979).

While less detailed in their explanation, Cohen and Felson also believed the shift to activities away from home explained the rise in violent crime. They argued that "the timing of work, schooling, and leisure may be of central importance for explaining crime rates" due to the separation of individuals from those they trust and the convergence of people of different backgrounds (Cohen & Felson, 1979, p. 591). The statistics supported this: in the years before the article, national victimization surveys on rape, assault, and personal larceny with contact showed that the crime rate in or near an individual's home was 839 per 100,000, while the rate was 3,610 away from home. More contact with strangers also increased the risk of victimization, as crime rates were seven times higher when carried out by a stranger to the victim than when carried out by a relative (Cohen & Felson, 1979). In short, the change in routine activities caused more people to be outside of their homes more often, also increasing their contact with strangers, both of which increase their "suitability," and thus their likelihood of criminal victimization.

The introduction of RAT laid major groundwork in the field of criminology. However, there are some holes I think we need to consider. For one, the original article does a relatively adequate job of explaining the rise of theft in the 1960s. However, how does the theory apply to other types of crimes, such as stalking? Can we create a more nuanced, in-depth explanation

using all three elements of the theory? Additionally, can we modernize the theory to include recent crime trends relating to cybercrime? Finally, we can apply RAT in terms of crime control, investigation, and deterrence. This will give us a better understanding of not only why offenders commit crimes, but what policymakers and designers can do to prevent such crimes from occurring.

III. Application to Stalking

I will start by examining how the theory applies to the crime of stalking. Studies consistently show that college women are the most at-risk population for being victims of stalking, defined as “repeated harassing or threatening behavior by an individual, such as following a person, appearing at a person’s home or college, making harassing phone calls, leaving written messages or objects, or destroying a person’s property” (Geistman, Smith, Lambert, & Cluse-Tolar, 2013, p. 51, as cited in Wood & Stichman, 2017, p. 487). Brady, Nobles, & Bouffard (2017) found that of 4,266 college students, a significant 4.1 percent had been stalked, compared with 2.2 percent of non-students. Of the 4.1 percent of students who were stalked, a majority (2.9 percent) were female. Another study of Canadian college students by Reyns, Henson, Fisher, Fox, & Nobles (2015) found that women were at double the risk of victimization, with ten percent of women reporting victimization. Wood and Stichman (2017) found that of women who are in college, significantly more report stalking victimization during their time as a college student rather than before attending a university. Therefore, applying RAT to stalking of college women specifically can be useful in discerning how specific activities or traits of college students may make them more susceptible. In other words, how do the three elements of RAT explain why college women are stalking victims at higher rates than others?

Starting with motivated offenders, the theory does not require we ask *why* the offenders are motivated; it simply assumes that there are always motivated offenders out there. It is worth noting, however, that college-aged men are the age group that commits the most crime. In 2023, for example, one estimate found that while eighteen- to twenty-five-year-olds made up less than ten percent of the American population, they accounted for twenty-five percent of all arrests (Chester & Barkin, 2022). Therefore, the proportion of “motivated offenders” is likely to be relatively high on college campuses, which in turn increases young women’s exposure to potential offenders. The theory also says that some of these young women must have some traits that make them suitable as targets, which is the most important element when applying the theory to stalking. First, being young and female are proven characteristics of suitable targets, and college students often have extremely predictable schedules, making them easier for an offender to stalk (Fisher, Cullen, & Turner, 2002). Beyond mere age and gender, however, other factors can make targets more suitable through the eyes of an offender.

Specifically, employment increased the risk of stalking victimization of women by fifteen percent (Elvey, Reyns, & McNeeley, 2018). Further, Reyns et al. (2015) specified that the frequency of going to work or school, along with the frequency of going to malls, restaurants, or theaters, was positively associated with the risk of stalking victimization. The reason for this is

simple: having a job and engaging in other public activities increases a person's time spent in public, which in turn increases the possibility of meeting a motivated offender (Mustaine & Tewksbury, 1999). Therefore, while offenders may not realize it, women with jobs and women who regularly go out in public are more "suitable" as targets. Another factor adding to target suitability is relationship status. Many young women in college either have or are trying to find a partner they can have a close, intimate relationship with, and this often means dating. It is also well documented that most female victims of stalking are (or have been) in a relationship with their stalker (Fisher et al., 2002). This fits with the fact that women who have some dating experience or are in a committed relationship are significantly more likely to be victims of stalking than women who have never dated (Fisher et al., 2002). Thus, a woman who has or is trying to find a partner is a suitable target in that they encounter more potential offenders who already have access to them, know a lot about them, and have a desire for them. This helps to explain why stalkers target women in college more than women who aren't students.

The use of drugs and alcohol also relates to target suitability. It is well known that college students like to have a good time: many of them party, go out with friends, and frequent bars. Drinking in public, however, increases a woman's risk of stalking victimization (Fisher et al., 2002; Mustaine & Tewksbury, 1999; Reyns & Scherer, 2017). Mustaine and Tewksbury (1999) specified that women in their study who were recently drunk in public were forty-three percent more likely to be victims of stalking, and women who reported buying illegal drugs were 1.33 times more likely to be victimized. Drinking or doing drugs can explain how a woman may appear suitable to a potential offender in several ways. Not only does being at places that serve alcohol increase a woman's exposure to motivated offenders, but such offenders who have also been drinking or doing drugs may become more hostile or confident, further increasing the woman's risk of victimization (Mustaine & Tewksbury, 1999). Further, being drunk or high makes a woman more vulnerable; they are easier to control and manipulate, may be physically or mentally impaired, and Mustaine & Tewksbury (1999) suggested that offenders may view women who have been drinking or doing illegal drugs as less likely to report any victimization to the authorities, as not to reveal their own crimes. Clearly, drinking alcohol or taking drugs clarifies how college women may be more likely to be suitable targets.

One final factor affecting target suitability is disability. According to Elvey et al. (2018), women with physical disabilities or limitations were seventy percent more likely to be victims of stalking. Reyns and Scherer (2017) further found that students with mental and learning disabilities were also at an increased risk. An offender may perceive someone with a disability as less likely to, or less able to, fight back or confront them, whether their victimization is physical or mental. In this way, they are much more vulnerable and thus more suitable than those without disabilities (Scherer, Snyder, & Fisher, 2016, as cited in Reyns & Scherer, 2017). This notion of disabilities also ties into the third element of RAT, guardianship. The victims may not be able to "guard" themselves; that is, they cannot fight back.

Other than disabilities, research has found only one guardianship factor significantly related to the crime of stalking – women's living situations. The following is an example of how

the *presence* of capable guardians can prevent stalking. Women living on campus experienced a sixty-two percent decrease in stalking victimizations (Mustaine & Tewksbury, 1999). Mustaine and Tewksbury (1999) pointed out that this was due to several guardians who get in the way of offenders in on-campus residences. It is likely that security systems are in place, such as keycards, cameras on the property, and check-in desks, and resident assistants and other residents also know who should be in their building and who shouldn't be. In short, stalking a student who lives on campus is difficult for offenders. They are surrounded by people who may be suspicious of them, and they may lack the requirements to even enter the building. Even if they stand outside, cameras are sure to capture them. Research also shows that, on the contrary, women who live alone are significantly more likely to be stalking victims (Fisher et al., 2002). This is an example in which there is a *lack* of capable guardianship. That is, there are no other people in the home for the victim to turn to or to witness the stalker's behavior, making them more vulnerable to being victimized.

IV. Application to Cyberstalking

Now that we've discussed how RAT can explain stalking and stalking victimization, let's turn to a more modern, yet equally important, issue: cybercrime. Studying how RAT applies to cybercrime requires some abstract thinking and slight revising of Cohen and Felson's (1979) original theory. All three elements are still needed for cybercrime to occur, but we need to rethink the part about convergence in space and time. Obviously, with cybercrime, it is plausible that the victim and the offender never meet face to face; they don't occupy the same physical "space," that is. As for time, it is also possible that this "convergence" doesn't happen. For example, an offender might send a text to the victim, but she doesn't read it until hours later. To account for this discrepancy, we need to rethink what constitutes the "convergence in space and time." Reyns, Henson, and Fisher (2011, p. 1152) explain that this convergence is not necessarily contingent on occupying the same physical space simultaneously, but rather depends on "(a) the network providing a conduit for interaction between victim and offender, with cyberspace acting as a proxy for physical space, and (b) an eventual overlap in time or a completed transaction across time." In other words, we need to refine this convergence in space to interaction in *cyberspace*, and the convergence in time to include asynchronous convergence.

Now that we understand the updated theory, let's apply it. Within the realm of cybercrime, we will look at cyberstalking specifically, which is "the repeated pursuit of an individual using electronic or Internet-capable devices," and can include email, text, phone, or other messages containing threats or harassment, as well as monitoring victims through cameras, computer programs, or listening devices (Reyns et al., 2011; Reyns, Henson, & Fisher, 2012, p. 1). Reyns et al. (2011) found that a relatively high proportion of college students were victims, with forty-six percent of female and thirty-two percent of male college students experiencing cyberstalking. Again, we will analyze the specific victimization of college students, as they are "an ideal population for studying cyberstalking victimization," according to Reyns et al. (2012,

p. 1154), because of “their high level of risk coupled with a propensity to routinely stay socially connected through a variety of electronic media.”

As with stalking, we don’t necessarily need to look at the offender’s motivations; we assume there are motivated offenders online. What matters is how the offenders choose their victims. Thus, let’s start with target suitability, in which Reyns et al. (2011) examined gender and relationship status in their study of 974 college students. Being female increased the risk of victimization by cyberstalkers by 180 percent. Being in a relationship, similarly, increased the risk of victimization by 1.5 times compared to single women, which is consistent with target suitability for non-cyberstalking. Offenders see women as more suitable, and people in a relationship may be more at risk because stalkers are (or were) often in a relationship with their victims. In addition, online behavior, or routine online activities, affects the risk of cyberstalking victimization, suggesting it also affects target suitability. The number of photos the student had posted online increased their chance of victimization, along with the number of times they updated their online accounts each day (Reyns et al., 2011). Marcum, Higgins, and Ricketts (2010) also found that if an individual provided personal information on their social networking sites, their risk of cyberstalking victimization significantly increased. It seems that the more an offender knows about a potential target, the more likely they will see that target as suitable, and the more likely they will pursue the target. In addition, the number of accounts the student had on social networks and the use of a messenger app were significantly and positively associated with cyberstalking victimization (Reyns et al., 2011). In general, offenders seem to victimize those with an extensive online presence. This suggests that a “suitable” target for cyberstalking depends largely on accessibility. An offender wants to make sure the victim is online enough to notice, acknowledge, and react to their communications.

In terms of guardianship, living alone or with a partner or roommate did not affect the risk of cyberstalking victimization of an individual, which differs from RAT’s application to non-cyberstalking. In fact, those who live with their parents were twice as likely to be victims of cyberstalking (Reyns, Henson, & Fisher, 2016). We also need to review this original concept of guardianship, which includes real people being physically present to prevent a crime. What Reyns et al. (2016, p. 162) called “offline guardians” are not “effective protectant[s] against online victimization.” This is due to a lack of ability to intervene as the crime occurs; they can only really act before or after an event has occurred, perhaps by educating individuals about online safety as a prevention measure or reporting the crime after it happens. Thus, we must look at the idea of guardianship under a different light. How can guardians be present *online*, or how can potential targets guard themselves online?

Let’s start with self-guardianship, in which research found one factor to be statistically significant. Reyns et al. (2011) found that allowing strangers to access one’s personal information online more than doubled the chance of being cyberstalked. Further, Reyns et al. (2016) concluded that when individuals allowed strangers to “friend” or “follow” them, the risk of cyberstalking increased by 250 percent. These numbers indicate that when one “guards” themselves by setting their account to private or rejecting follow requests from strangers, they are

much less likely to be victims of cyberstalking. This also ties in to target suitability in the sense that these individuals who guard themselves from strangers in such ways are less accessible, and therefore less suitable. Another guardianship factor measured by Reyns et al. (2016, p. 158) was peer deviance. They asked respondents “how likely they think it is that a friend will use the information they have posted online to harass, stalk, or threaten them.” The idea here is that when an individual’s peers, who would normally be some of their guardians, are more deviant, then that individual is less likely to have capable online guardians other than themselves. Reyns et al.’s (2016) hypothesis was correct: they found that respondents who classified their peers as more deviant were thirty percent more likely to be cyberstalked. In practice, this means that at least some online peer guardianship can help prevent cyberstalking from occurring. These two factors clearly fit with Cohen and Felson’s (1979) original RAT: even if a motivated offender and a suitable target converge in cyberspace, capable guardians can prevent a crime from happening. Or, in the case of peer deviance, a lack of capable guardians can enable a crime to occur.

V. Policy Implications

If RAT has some empirical merit and can explain many different crimes, then it must also have some implications for how to deal with crime. However, we should expect such implications to differ from other forms of crime control, as most criminologists “have long sought to explain differences in propensity for law-violating behavior, often referred to as criminality” (Wilcox, 2015, p. 772). Routine activity theorists, though, “have reoriented scholarship away from trying to understand criminality and toward an understanding of crime events instead” (Wilcox, 2015, 772). In other words, crime policies derived from RAT don’t focus on what causes an individual to commit a crime; instead, they focus on specific events and activities that may present an opportunity for an offender to commit a crime. One method for preventing crime that borrows RAT’s ideas is situational crime prevention (SCP), which “seeks to develop crime- and situation-specific methods and techniques for limiting and eliminating criminal opportunities” (Reyns, 2010, p. 106). SCP posits five techniques for reducing criminal opportunities: increasing the risk for the offender, increasing effort needed to commit the crime, reducing the rewards stemming from the crime, removing excuses, and reducing provocations (Reyns, 2010).

Within the realm of SCP lies crime prevention through environmental design (CPTED). The idea of CPTED is to design buildings, outdoor spaces, and other areas using architecture and features thought to reduce crime by reducing the opportunity for potential offenders. There are five elements of CPTED, which align closely with the components of SCP. First is natural surveillance, which suggests that increasing visibility in a particular area enables the users of that area to quickly notice any suspicious activity. Additionally, the feeling of being watched may deter some offenders from committing a crime in such areas (Shariati, 2022). Natural surveillance largely corresponds with increasing risk from SCP. Second is access control, which aligns with increasing effort and refers to “limiting unauthorized access to an area in an effort to reduce criminal opportunities” (Shariati, 2022, p. 1200). The third element of CPTED is

territoriality, which shows a clear distinction of space through physical and symbolic barriers, indicating the space is well monitored. Fourth is maintenance, or the upkeep of a space to indicate ownership and a sense of community control. Territoriality and maintenance often correspond with increasing risk and removing excuses. Finally is the element of activity support, or the encouragement of “the presence of legitimate users in an area” to “promote the intended use of space” (Shariati, 2022, p. 1201).

Let’s apply SCP and CPTED to stalking and cyberstalking. Perhaps the most important elements of these crime prevention techniques, respectively, are access control and increased effort, especially for cyberstalking. In terms of stalking, we already discussed the use of keycards to access certain buildings and the presence of employees or guardians at the entrance of the building. Regarding cyberstalking, we know that offenders like to have as much personal information as possible about their possible victims; it makes them more suitable (Marcum et al., 2010; Reyns et al., 2011). Thus, limiting or controlling potential offenders’ access to this information is crucial. People who use social networks, especially college women, should consider changing their profiles to “private” so the public cannot see the things or photos they post unless they accept them as a friend or follower. Potential targets may also consider filtering incoming messages on social sites. For example, they can identify certain messages as suspicious or from an unknown sender. They can then block that user from messaging them again, effectively controlling a potential offender’s access to the target.

However, advising potential targets to change their activities because they may come into contact with an offender is somewhat problematic and, in some ways, can be interpreted as victim-blaming. Therefore, we should take a look at what the administrators of these social websites, or place managers, can do. Reyns (2010, p. 104) clarified, “If websites are places, then website administrators, webmasters, and designers are their place managers...They can manipulate the online environment at will, limit access, and set rules for participation.” Regarding policy, this might mean that all accounts are set to private by default, or the use of a built-in program to automatically filter incoming messages. They should also consider a more widespread use of a verification system. For example, before a user can access a person’s email address, phone number, personal information such as gender and age, and pictures they have posted, administrators may require them to verify their identity. This may deter some offenders, but even if not, then the place managers know the offender’s identity. All these policies effectively reduce the number of targets seen as suitable by potential offenders by reducing their access to personal information. They also increase the effort it takes for a potential offender to pursue a victim, making it less likely they will try to stalk them.

Two other corresponding elements of CPTED and SCP, natural surveillance and increasing risk, are also applicable to stalking and cyberstalking. The purpose of natural surveillance in crime prevention is to create an environment in which potential offenders are more visible or easier to notice, and in turn, offenders may be deterred because they feel they are being watched (Shariati, 2022). In terms of physical spaces, creating this visibility may include improving students’ lines of sight through large and abundant windows and doors. Proper

lighting is also important, especially at night, and designers should limit the number of potential hiding spots for offenders (Reyns, 2010). In an online environment, natural surveillance is harder to apply, but there are still tactics to make offenders feel as if someone is watching them. For example, opportunities to report suspicious or stalking behavior should be ample and easily accessible. These “report” buttons should be visible at every corner of the website, notifying offenders that they will be caught if they try to engage in inappropriate behavior. Place managers may also design online social networks in a way that nobody can be anonymous, at least to website administrators or place managers. Seong-Sik and Sun Park (2025) found that offenders are significantly more likely to pursue victims online if they believe others cannot see their identity. If place managers can see everyone’s identity, and (through the proposals of natural surveillance), they make this clear to users, offenders may be deterred from committing cybercrimes. The above techniques increase the visibility of offenders for both place managers, who serve as guardians, and all website users, who may be potential targets or offenders. Therefore, capable guardians are more present, and place managers are more likely to identify misbehavior and criminal activity from offenders (that is, the risk of committing a crime increases), thereby diminishing an offender’s perceived opportunity for crime.

The final CPTED elements I wish to discuss are maintenance and territoriality, which generally overlap with increasing risk and removing excuses. The recommendations derived from maintenance and territoriality are very similar for both stalking and cyberstalking, and have to do with clear guidelines. On college campuses, administrators should clearly and accurately define stalking, what it entails, and its consequences in their student codes of conduct. Information about stalking and victim services should also be readily available on the college website or campus police site. For online social networks, this information (as it pertains to cyberstalking) should be present in the terms and agreements, which users must agree to to use the site. Website administrators should also consider frequent reminders (e.g., pop-up boxes in apps) about what constitutes cyberstalking, safety information, and how to report other users. Physical campuses can do this as well by posting flyers and sending email reminders. These policies have one caveat, however, which is to actually get students and users to read the terms of service and codes of conduct. Reyns et al. (2010) suggest making these texts more accessible. For example, the information could be shorter or organized in bullet points. Online, there could be several checkboxes so users could agree to individual policies rather than agreeing to all at once. If administrators include information about stalking and cyberstalking in their codes of conduct and terms, motivate students to read it, and post regular reminders about it, potential offenders have no excuses for committing the crimes that these documents identify. Also, since potential victims also have access to this information, they may be more likely to report any crimes that occur, increasing the risk for the offender.

VI. Conclusion

The above policy implications have one thing in common: they limit the opportunity for crime to occur. That is, they decrease the chance that an offender will come into contact with a

target in the absence of a capable guardian. Since its introduction in 1979, RAT has reframed scholarly conversation about crime, shifting focus from the offender to the circumstances in which offenders commit crime. The theory continues to stand as a relevant and enduring criminological framework because of its flexible application to many different types of crime and its helpful insights into policymaking. By examining the theory's three elements – a motivated offender, a suitable target, and the lack of capable guardianship – I created an explanation for why stalking and cyberstalking occur, especially among college women. College women often serve as extremely suitable targets due to their age, gender, and tendency to date young men (who could be potential offenders). The fact that disabled women or women who live alone are more likely to be stalking victims also illustrates the importance of guardianship. I also discussed how RAT is extremely flexible as society and technology change through its ability to explain cybercrime. By redefining what constitutes a convergence of the three elements in space and time, I applied those elements to cyberstalking with the evidence of increased risk of victimization when targets share more personal information.

These applications show us that crime, at least in part, does rely on the offender's opportunity to commit a crime, not only their motivations. This means, then, that crime prevention strategies informed by RAT focus on how to design physical and digital spaces in ways that decrease a potential offender's opportunity by increasing guardianship, decreasing target suitability, or simply preventing those things from converging with offenders. Specifically, CPTED and SCP strive to increase the risk and effort for offenders while reducing rewards and excuses through natural surveillance, access control, territoriality, and maintenance. While these crime prevention policies show promise, RAT does not necessarily need to stop improving. Even Cohen and Felson (1979, p. 605) explained, "We have focused specific attention upon violations themselves and prerequisites for their occurrence...the routine activity approach might in the future be applied to the analysis of offenders and their inclinations as well." Further research might examine the reasons behind motivation – a step beyond the current theory, which simply assumes offenders are motivated. This, I think, would be a huge step forward for the theory, not only equating it with other criminological theories, but rising above other theories due to its simultaneous attention to crime opportunity.

VII. Connection to Law

While routine activity theory may not be the dominant presumption in criminology today, there is a reason it has stuck with criminologists and sociologists for decades since its introduction in 1979. Being one of the first theories to look *outside* the offender to predict and explain crime, it can give us a different outlook on crime that is not entirely psychological. By examining the theory's three elements of a motivated offender, a suitable target, and a lack of capable guardianship, criminologists and policy makers have come up with a framework called crime prevention through environmental design, which has huge implications for preventing crime. It raises credible suggestions for physical spaces to deter crime, and thereby possible legal action to require the use of some elements of crime prevention through environmental design in

public spaces. These suggestions raised by routine activity theory are unique in the sense that they don't require intervention in the lives of individuals to prevent crime; they simply require minor changes to buildings and public spaces.

Furthermore, routine activity theory is uniquely flexible in the realm of criminological theories. While it originally was used to explain the massive rise in crime in the 1960s and '70s, its elements can just as effectively be used to explain micro-level, individual crimes. I show this flexibility in the theory's application to the relatively new crime of cyberstalking, which gives rise to even more legal or policy frameworks to prevent crime from taking place online, rather than in a physical space. Specifically, policymakers and legislators need to enact requirements for strong verification systems, filtering messages, and automatically setting social media accounts to private. While routine activity theory largely gives recommendations for intervention to prevent crime, it can also help explain why people commit crime in the first place, how they come into contact with the criminal justice system, and why we punish crime the way we do.

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Nationalism and State-Building After the Collapse of the USSR

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I. Nationalism and State-Building After the Collapse of the USSR

The collapse of the USSR in 1991 changed the geopolitical landscape of Eurasia and created 15 independent republics that had to build new political systems, national identities, and state institutions. Nationalism became a significant tool for state-building after the Soviet collapse because these new states inherited diverse populations, disputed borders, Soviet-era divisions, and older inter-ethnic tensions. Recent literature argues that the transition to independence in the post-Soviet region did not automatically create stable or fully unified states. Instead, it forced new governments to build legitimacy, define national identity, and create unity within ethnically and linguistically diverse populations (Binici, 2022). Post-1991 nationalism became both an attempt to create unity and a source of conflict and separatism.

Post-Soviet nationalism was shaped by Soviet political legacies. The Soviet Union recognized titular nations inside the republics while also promoting Soviet identity and Russification. The republics in the former Soviet Union had a connection to specific ethnicities, and titular groups had a feeling that they were “owners” of their republics during the Soviet Union’s existence (Amasyalı & Tarasov, 2025). As a result, when the Soviet Union collapsed, many political elites emphasized titular cultures, histories, and languages as a foundation for statehood. However, because nationalism often created tension between civic citizenship and ethnic identity, it also contributed to ethnic conflict in multiethnic republics such as Kazakhstan, Georgia, Moldova, and Ukraine. This paper argues that nationalism shaped post-Soviet state-building in two connected ways: it helped new states create legitimacy and unity after the collapse of the USSR, but it also deepened minority tensions, separatism, and territorial conflict. The cases of Kazakhstan, Moldova, Transnistria, Abkhazia, South Ossetia, and Nagorno-Karabakh show that nationalism was not simply good or bad. Instead, it became a political tool that could hold states together in some cases while breaking them apart in others.

II. Theoretical Foundations of Nationalism and Nation-Building

Defining the Nation and Nationalism

Academic studies of post-Soviet state-building build on larger debates about what a nation is and how nationalism works in politics. There are some scholars who view nations as historically continuous groups united by common ethnicity, culture, language, faith, and shared heritage. In contrast to this approach, some see nations as relatively new creations of state politics and ideological discourse. According to Binici (2022), these two approaches to the analysis of nations could be explained by seeing nations as natural phenomena on the one hand, and socially constructed political formations on the other. The notion of imagined communities, which originates from the theories of Benedict Anderson, is essential in studying the post-Soviet context of nation-building since it explains why people can feel connected to others they do not personally know but still view as part of the same nation (Binici, 2022).

It is important to distinguish between nationalism and nation-building while also recognizing how closely connected they are in the post-Soviet context. Nationalism refers to political attempts to connect state power with national identity, while nation-building involves the creation of political institutions, symbols, and narratives that foster solidarity and legitimacy. As Manukyan (2025) explains, nation-building refers to the process of providing justification for why populations should think of themselves as forming a united whole. Similarly, Cederman (2024) argues that modern political constructs cannot fully explain nationalism because historical memory, territory, and myths have been crucial for nationalist movements. This shows that nationalism is not only a modern political project. It is also tied to older memories, symbols, and claims about land. Recent literature recognizes that nationalism should be analyzed through both state politics and historical legacy (Cederman, 2024).

Civic and Ethnic Nationalism

Although scholars use many different models presented in scholarly works, ethnic and civic nationalism have been the most popular conceptual models used to understand post-Soviet state-building. The first concept defines nationality using objective criteria such as common ancestry, language, culture, religion, and other features passed from generation to generation without individual consent. Thus, ethnic nationalism implies membership from birth, which may lead to various forms of discrimination against minorities. According to Binici (2022), ethnicity-based nationalism often promotes assimilation, making it easier for the titular group to dominate in the process of state-building. The civic concept defines the nation through political association and citizenship, emphasizing equal rights and obligations for all individuals regardless of ethnic origin. In theory, civic nationalism seems better suited for post-Soviet states because many of them inherited mixed populations and complicated histories. In practice, however, governments often found it difficult to separate citizenship from ethnicity because the new states were trying to prove their independence after decades of Soviet control (Binici, 2022).

Despite this theoretical advantage, most post-Soviet countries did not adopt either model exclusively and instead relied on a combination of both approaches. Binici (2022) claims that the hybrid approach was shaped by the need to protect sovereignty, prevent separatism, and provide state legitimacy after the fall of the USSR. Most nation-building projects included efforts to restore national traditions that had been repressed during the Soviet period. At the same time, these efforts sometimes created conflict with minorities who felt excluded from the new national identity. Manukyan (2025) claims that due to these realities, the ethnic-civic dichotomy is losing its analytical power because most nation-building projects are built on a mix of ethnic and civic approaches.

III. Soviet Legacies and the Rise of Post-Soviet Nationalism

Soviet Nationality Policies and Identity Formation

Literature suggests that Soviet nationality policies provided the foundations for post-Soviet nationalism. While the Soviets claimed to support socialist internationalism, they also institutionalized ethnicity through territorial republics, official national categories, and language policies. According to Amasyalı and Tarasov (2025), the Soviet republics were strongly linked to titular ethnicities, which created the idea that each ethnic group had its own territory even before independence. Through this, Soviet governance created the structures through which ethnicity could gain political meaning, encouraging people to think of territory as belonging to a nation instead of weakening that connection. The legacy of these practices was clear after 1991, when new states used Soviet-era territorial and administrative structures to build sovereignty, identity, and legitimacy after the collapse of the empire (Amasyalı & Tarasov, 2025).

The policies related to Russification, migration, and population engineering also made post-Soviet nationalism more complicated by creating highly diverse societies. According to Binici (2022), the Soviet state promoted the Russian language and culture, while also relocating or deporting people in Central Asia and the Caucasus. This led to very mixed societies. For instance, Binici mentions Kazakhstan, which experienced different population inflows because of migration and deportation policies, including people of German, Korean, and Crimean-Tatar ethnicity (Binici, 2022). This created complex ethnic structures, and after the fall of the Soviet Union, it became difficult for newly created states to build nations because their populations had different identities and conflicting histories. Manukyan (2025) argues that post-Soviet nations had to fill the legitimacy vacuum left after the fall of Soviet ideology with nationalism by connecting sovereignty to history, culture, and territory. In this way, nationalism became a replacement for Soviet ideology, but it also brought older ethnic and historical tensions back into politics.

Language Policies and Cultural Revival

Language policies became one of the most visible instruments of post-Soviet nation-building because language represented both cultural and political identity. As stated by Amasyalı and Tarasov (2025), many Soviet republics introduced laws promoting national languages after, and sometimes during, independence in an attempt to strengthen national identity and reduce Russian dominance. These language reforms were seen as one of the clearest ways for new states to separate themselves from Soviet influence. By emphasizing national languages, states wanted to strengthen the political identities of their communities and create a clear contrast with Soviet imperial traditions. Thus, language policy became one of the tools that helped states imagine and build new political communities.

At the same time, language reforms often became sources of ethnic tension and even political conflict. For instance, according to Binici (2022), Kazakhstan had difficulties with language reform because policies supporting the national language worried Russian-speaking minorities living in northern areas. This created a difficult balance: promoting the Kazakh language strengthened independence, but it also risked making minorities feel politically insecure. Similar situations occurred in other post-Soviet cases, such as Moldova and its

separatist territories. According to Dembińska (2023), Moldova introduced reforms in its language legislation in 1989, which alarmed Russophone people in Transnistria and helped create conditions for armed conflict and separatism.

IV. Nationalism and Minority Policies in Post-Soviet States

Kazakhstan and the Challenge of Multiethnic Nation-Building

Kazakhstan is regarded as one of the most significant cases for studying nation-building in a post-Soviet multiethnic setting. According to Binici (2022), Kazakhstan was characterized by a highly diverse population that included Kazakhs, Russians, Ukrainians, Germans, Uyghurs, Koreans, and others, with Kazakhs making up only a narrow numerical majority in the country. This created several risks, including ethnic conflict, regional instability, territorial vulnerability, and separatism, especially in areas close to Russia. For this reason, the government chose to follow a mixed civic and ethnic model of nation-building. This included rhetoric centered around citizenship, harmony, and stability, while also supporting the language, symbols, and ethnonational identity of the titular people. Such measures were seen as a way to strengthen sovereignty and form a titular nation without undermining the stability of a diverse state (Binici, 2022).

Studies show that Kazakhstan reflected some of the general trends in post-Soviet nation-building. Specifically, scholars argue that the policies implemented in Kazakhstan show how stability and ethnic revival could be pursued at the same time instead of being viewed as opposites. The post-independence leadership worked to promote diversity and accommodate minorities for the sake of social harmony and political unity. At the same time, ethnic revival played a major role in countering Russification and reinforcing state sovereignty. Similarly, according to Manukyan (2025), Kazakhstan represents an example of a post-Soviet country where civic state-building and ethnic nation-building worked together in pursuit of geopolitical goals. In other words, nation-building could include both integration and ethnic revival because both were needed to address specific challenges. Kazakhstan is important because it shows the central dilemma of post-Soviet nationalism. If the state focused too much on Kazakh identity, it risked alienating Russian-speaking minorities. If it avoided Kazakh identity completely, it risked weakening the meaning of independence itself. This is why Kazakhstan's nationalism was not simply ethnic or civic, but a careful balance between both.

Minority Rights and International Norms

The problem of minorities became a key political concern after the fall of the Soviet Union, when it became clear that many new states had large populations with cultural and political ties to neighboring countries. International organizations also played an important role by shaping discussions around minority rights. For instance, Binici (2022) mentions the role of

institutions such as the United Nations, the Council of Europe, and the Organization for Security and Cooperation in Europe in establishing policies related to discrimination, linguistic rights, and culture. The goal was to create an inclusive environment where minorities could preserve their identity in independent states. At the same time, it was difficult to implement these policies because governments often viewed minority claims as security threats rather than human rights issues. The fear of separatism and state collapse often meant that ethnic policies pursued by post-Soviet governments did not fully align with liberal minority rights.

Nation-building in post-Soviet states usually happened in the context of geopolitical risk and minority-rights concerns. Policies were often presented as necessary for political stability and sovereignty. However, these policies could negatively affect minorities who saw them as attempts to suppress their identity. Specifically, Binici (2022) notes that policies promoting titular languages, culture, and symbols tended to reinforce divisions when minorities viewed them as discriminatory. In addition, nation-building could take a different turn in separatist regions where nationalist movements further entrenched the boundaries between titular and minority groups. This shows that minority policy was not only a legal issue. It was also tied to the larger question of who belonged inside the new nation.

V. Separatism and De Facto States in the Post-Soviet Space

The Emergence of Separatist Regions

Post-Soviet nationalism led to the emergence of separatist regions and de facto states. According to Dembińska (2023), regions such as Transnistria, Abkhazia, South Ossetia, and Nagorno-Karabakh created state-like structures after violent wars in the 1990s. Despite not being internationally recognized, these separatist states created legitimacy and identity through nationalism. The current literature highlights the relationship between post-Soviet separatism and fears of exclusion. For example, the elite in Transnistria feared the threat of Moldovan nationalism and Romanianization. According to Dembińska (2023), separatists used independence to claim that they were protecting themselves and “real” Moldovans from the nationalist aggression of Chisinau. In this regard, nation-building in Transnistria took the form of creating a supra-ethnic identity that included Russians, Ukrainians, and Moldovans.

There was also the creation of alternative narratives regarding territorial ownership. In Nagorno-Karabakh, for instance, nationalism was used to stress historical links with Artsakh and memories of Azerbaijani aggression. According to Dembińska (2023), symbolic politics, educational history, and myths of territorial ownership helped legitimize separatist movements and identity. This also happened in Abkhazia and South Ossetia, where the narrative of victimhood and resistance to Georgian nationalism played a major role in nation-building. From this standpoint, nationalism affected both recognized states and separatist territories seeking recognition. It helped separatist leaders explain why separation was necessary, while also making compromise with the parent state much harder.

Nation-Building in De Facto States

Literature on separatist states shows that nationalism was used to create political stability in unrecognized states. Dembińska (2023) explains how separatists sought legitimacy by building a national identity, creating a distinct national narrative, and defining borders. In some cases, the “enemy” state became an important part of nation-building. For example, Abkhazia developed its nationalizing state by emphasizing Abkhaz ethnic identity and portraying Georgians as internal enemies. The public sphere in Abkhazia was filled with symbols of violence and victimhood. Similarly, South Ossetian nationalism emphasized Georgian nationalism and the idea of unification with North Ossetia under Russian rule. According to Dembińska (2023), however, South Ossetia did not develop a strong separate national identity because its political project centered more on joining Russia. The literature also shows that symbolic politics played a role in maintaining separatist state stability. For example, separatist states used flags, maps, educational programs, monuments, and historical narratives to symbolize their claim to territory. Through such symbolism, separatists claimed unity as a state despite lacking recognition. As a result, nationalism became both a survival mechanism and a tool of state-building.

VI. Nationalism, Territory, and State Transformation

Territoriality and National Identity

Cederman (2024) argues that one of the problems in nationalism studies is the tendency to overlook territoriality. Since nations are often defined by their homelands, it is difficult to imagine nationalism without territory. In the post-Soviet space, territoriality had special meaning because states inherited borders that did not always match ethnic divisions. The literature reveals that nationalist movements and conflicts were often driven by territorial issues. In post-Soviet states, territorial integrity was seen as crucial to sovereignty, while ethnic minorities and separatists sought self-determination based on ethnic or historical ties to specific regions. As pointed out by Cederman (2024), nationalism is likely to result in conflict whenever political borders do not align with national identities. This was clearly seen in the former Soviet republics when Soviet borders became international borders in 1991.

Territorial nationalism also influenced geopolitical instability. According to Cederman (2024), the problem with nationalism is that its destabilizing effects are often underestimated when scholars do not pay enough attention to territorial disputes. The examples of post-Soviet wars in Georgia, Moldova, Azerbaijan, and Ukraine show the negative influence of nationalist territorial claims. Different historical narratives and competing territorial claims deepened conflict and made compromise more difficult.

Historical Memory and Political Legitimacy

Historical memory was another major part of post-Soviet nationalism. Cederman (2024) emphasizes that nationalism cannot be understood without collective memory, heroic myths, and historical narratives. Because of that, the rewriting of history became important for post-Soviet elites. The current research indicates that historical memories in the post-Soviet space were commonly linked to victimhood and resistance. According to Dembińska (2023), separatists used memories of violence and oppression to legitimize separatism. South Ossetia, for instance, celebrated monuments to the victims of war with Georgia. In Nagorno-Karabakh, Armenians relied on the idea of continuous historical presence on the land as heirs to ancient Armenian civilization.

At the same time, historical memory could help shape national identity in post-Soviet states. Binici (2022) explains that narratives emphasizing the revival of Kazakh culture after years of Soviet control are popular in Kazakhstan. These history-based narratives helped legitimize independence and encourage patriotism. However, different memories may lead to tensions among ethnically diverse populations because groups interpret Soviet history differently. This matters because post-Soviet state-building was not only about creating institutions. It was also about deciding which version of history would define the nation.

VII. Comparative Patterns in Post-Soviet Nation-Building

Similarities Across Post-Soviet States

Research literature shows that there were common features in the structure of post-Soviet nation-building. First, states pursuing sovereignty emphasized the importance of their national cultures. This argument is supported by Amasyalı and Tarasov (2025), who note that this practice can be explained by decolonization and the creation of nation-states after the collapse of empires. To distinguish themselves from Soviet influence, states promoted national cultures, images, and memories.

Second, the majority of post-Soviet states struggled with tension between civic and ethnic nationalism. Although many states used civic language, their policies were still often shaped by ethnic identity. Binici (2022) explains that this was a compromise and a way to preserve national identity and state stability. Consequently, nation-building was justified politically while still supported by ethnic identity. Third, because post-Soviet states inherited diverse populations, territorial disputes, and ethno-territorial arrangements, nationalism became a defining element of politics in the region. The way the Soviet Union structured its borders led to the alignment of different ethnic communities with particular states or regions. After the dissolution of the USSR, such alignments provided ground for nationalism and secessionist movements. Therefore, nationalism became a key feature of post-Soviet politics.

Differences in Nationalist Trajectories

The development of nationalist movements varied because post-Soviet states had different levels of ethnic diversity and different geopolitical concerns. Comparative analysis shows that Kazakhstan was in a special position because of its multiethnic population and its need to balance relations with Russia. To ensure stability, Kazakhstan incorporated civic nationalism within a broader ethnic national project. Stronger ethnocentric nationalism can be observed in secessionist regions shaped by violent conflict.

Dembińska (2023) points out that each separatist de facto state built national identity in a way that reflected its own local situation. For example, Transnistria did not pursue a strictly ethnic agenda because there was no dominant ethnicity in the region. Abkhazia was characterized by titular nationalism and minority management. South Ossetia relied on indirect assimilation to Russia, while the formation of a separate state-centered identity was not a priority. These examples reveal the flexibility of national identity-building depending on the political and demographic situation.

Finally, numerous authors suggest that post-Soviet nationalism was shaped by external factors. Due to geography and ethnic composition, Russia remained an important factor. As noted by Binici (2022), fear of imperial expansion and political intervention was among the major motivations for creating minority policies in Kazakhstan. Post-Soviet states were also influenced by Russian political, military, and economic power. In other words, post-Soviet nationalism was also shaped by Russia's continued regional influence and by fears of Russian political, cultural, and military intervention.

VIII. Conclusion

Nationalism was one of the most important forces shaping post-Soviet state-building after the collapse of the USSR. Soviet disintegration led to a struggle for national identity and sovereignty, with nationalism playing a major role in this process. From this perspective, nationalism was not only a source of unity but also a source of division. Various policies concerning language, citizenship, and culture were used for nation-building in post-Soviet states. However, these policies often prioritized the majority nation and created discontent among minorities.

In this respect, literature demonstrates that post-Soviet nationalism goes beyond the civic/ethnic dichotomy. In most cases, post-Soviet states pursued a hybrid approach because they had to respond to historical legacies, demographic realities, and geopolitical challenges. Kazakhstan provides a strong example of this hybrid approach. Separatist movements in Transnistria, Abkhazia, South Ossetia, and Nagorno-Karabakh show the role of nationalism in state fragmentation. Overall, nationalism became both a foundation for state-building and a cause of fragmentation. It helped new governments claim legitimacy, promote national culture, and distance themselves from Soviet rule, but it also made minority politics, territorial disputes, and separatist movements harder to resolve.

IX. Connection to Law

This research connects to law because nationalism after the collapse of the USSR was not only about identity, culture, or history. It also shaped laws about citizenship, language, minority rights, borders, and state recognition. When the Soviet Union collapsed, the new states had to decide who belonged inside the nation and what kind of legal identity the state would have. These decisions were not simple because many post-Soviet countries inherited mixed populations, disputed borders, and communities with ties to neighboring states. Because of this, nationalism became connected to law almost immediately. One of the strongest legal issues in this paper is the tension between majority nation-building and minority protections. New states used laws to promote national languages, symbols, and cultures after decades of Soviet control. In some cases, these laws helped build unity and strengthen sovereignty. However, they also made some minorities feel excluded or threatened. This is why minority policy was not just a cultural issue. It became a legal issue about discrimination, language rights, political participation, and equal citizenship. Kazakhstan shows how a state can try to balance civic citizenship with ethnic revival, while Moldova, Georgia, and the separatist regions show how these questions can turn into conflict. This paper also connects to international law through the issue of separatism and de facto states. Places like Transnistria, Abkhazia, South Ossetia, and Nagorno-Karabakh created state-like systems, but they were not fully recognized by the international community. This raises legal questions about territorial integrity, self-determination, recognition, and the rights of people living in unrecognized states. Overall, this research matters because it shows that nationalism can build states, but it can also divide them. Law becomes the tool that decides how identity is protected, how minorities are treated, and how borders are defended or challenged.

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A Country Under Control:

An Analysis of Russia's Autocracy

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I. Introduction

Few countries today are as powerful and disruptive as Vladimir Putin's Russia. Currently at the center of the world's attention due to its invasion of Ukraine, Russia has significant influence over the global order through political alliances and trade agreements, as well as military conflicts and cyberattacks. Although Russia claims to be a thriving democracy, the country is known among experts to be a competitive authoritarian regime. Putin employs rigged elections and manipulates legal decisions to maintain power through an 'uneven playing field,' a topic explored in detail by Lucan Ahmad Way and Steven Levitsky in their 2019 article "How Autocrats Can Rig the Game and Damage Democracy" in the Washington Post. Still, some claim that Putin's high approval ratings and Russia's general political stability point to its democratic nature, yet these assertions do not analyze the deeper structural elements of Russia's autocracy. Analyzing whether Russia is an autocracy requires defining what autocracy truly means, exploring Russia's political history, identifying key counterarguments, and examining how Russia fits at least three of the main autocratic indicators through its centralized political system authority, control of the media, and political and social suppression.

II. Background Information

First, defining what is – and is not – an autocracy is necessary when analyzing Russia's government. According to Merriam-Webster dictionary, an autocracy is "a government in which one person possesses unlimited power" (Merriam-Webster). When applied to Russia, this definition may be true in practice, but it is quite vague – especially for a country that claims to have legislative separation, judicial review, and consistent elections. Thus, analyzing Russia requires a more in-depth analysis of autocratic power. To achieve this, political scientists Steven Levitsky and Lucan Way have developed the concept of competitive authoritarianism. This concept describes how "democracy can be fundamentally compromised" through the creation of an "uneven playing field" in which politicians use "administrative powers to strengthen their party and systematically deny the opposition access to crucial resources, media, or state institutions" (Levitsky and Way, 2019, p. 1). In other words, autocrats often utilize existing political institutions to consolidate control while using the veil of democracy to cover their abuses of power. Levitsky and Way specify that this can manifest in politicians auditing businesses, generating biased media sources, manipulating rules and elections, and packing "judiciaries, electoral commissions and other nominally independent bodies to ensure that the incumbent will win critical electoral, legal or other disputes" (Levitsky and Way, 2019, p. 2). In this way, the concept of competitive authoritarianism offers realistic and practical criteria for comparing regimes.

In addition to understanding the actions autocrats take, it is also vital to know what factors lead to authoritarian regimes in the first place. Autocrats usually rise in states “plagued by corruption, bureaucratic inefficiency, and fiscal scarcity,” as these conditions create opportunities to seize control and “coordinate elites” while “doling out the spoils of power to keep them happy and in the regime’s camp” (Levitsky and Way, 2023, p. 16). This makes a lack of both political trust and economic security detrimental to democracy. On top of political and economic instability, “resource concentration is a recipe for autocracy,” when the “state monopolizes the main sources of wealth and income,” effectively forcing citizens to “depend on the government for resources,” while “denying rivals and critics access to much-needed resources” and “offering favorable access to loyalists” (Levitsky and Way, 2023, p. 10). Governmental dependence and control of citizens quell democratic reform, especially when the state permeates all aspects of daily life. This is because “democracy requires opposition,” and “power asymmetries,” combined with “citizens who fear losing their jobs, income, or housing,” result in a civic base “less likely to join civic or opposition organizations” (Levitsky and Way, 2023, p. 11). This means that the existing social, political, and economic conditions in a state shape how easily autocrats can consolidate power – a concept that is clear when analyzing Russia’s post-Soviet Union development.

III. Russian History

Looking at Russian political history is necessary to explain Putin’s current regime. Being the largest republic in the USSR, Russia effectively replaced the Soviet Union during its collapse in 1991 after General Secretary Gorbachev’s failed reforms “unleashed forces out of his control that eventually combined to produce nascent democracy, economic disarray, and state collapse” (McFaul, 2021, p. 13). Russian President Boris Yeltsin then set out to address these issues by pushing Russia towards the Western ideals of market freedom and private ownership. However, his deregulation and privatization, labeled economic shock therapy, ultimately resulted in skyrocketing inflation and mass layoffs (Kagarlitsky, 2002, p. 92). Meanwhile, former Soviet elites quickly bought out entire companies through Yeltsin’s failed voucher program, solidifying their grip on key industries. Yeltsin’s economic reforms wreaked havoc on citizens, as living standards declined, and manufacturing came to a standstill. On top of this economic instability, political conflict broke out in October of 1993 when Yeltsin disbanded parliament and shelled the building in response to calls to limit his presidential power and end his sweeping reforms. This marked a turning point in the role of president, allowing Yeltsin to consolidate political control and expand presidential power through a constitutional vote in December of the same year (Kagarlitsky, 2002, p. 89). However, this political instability also forced Yeltsin to rely on outside support. For instance, during his 1996 re-election campaign, Yeltsin “took financial support” from “Russia’s richest oligarchs in return for shares in lucrative companies” through his loans-for-shares program (McFaul, 2021, p. 16). While this “insider scheme” helped Yeltsin secure victory, it ultimately “tarnished the legitimacy of privatization, discredited his entire

market-reform agenda, and undermined support for democracy more generally, since many Russians saw the new system of government as synonymous with corruption” (McFaul, 2021, p. 16). These turbulent economic, social, and political conditions are exactly the factors that contribute to the rise of an autocrat, as most people yearned for order and stability after years of chaos and confusion.

The Russian people found their apparent savior in Vladimir Putin, a young KGB agent-turned politician whom Yeltsin handpicked as his successor before he resigned in 1999 (McFaul, 2021, p. 19). Although relatively unknown, Putin leveraged Yeltsin’s backing and the war in Chechnya to portray himself as a capable and committed leader, eventually winning the 2000 Presidential election (Kagarlitsky, 2002, p. 259). However, Putin still had a difficult task ahead, considering “Yeltsin had left his successor with a war that could not be won, an economy which could not be restored to health without a ruthless redivision of property, and a state which could not be governed without resort to lies, provocations and manipulations” (Kagarlitsky, 2002, p. 266). In other words, the turbulent nature of Russia’s economic collapse, social upheaval, and political instability facilitated – and seemingly justified – Putin’s ever-increasing grip on power. Once in office, Putin worked to “immediately rein in autonomous political institutions, organizations, and individuals that could constrain presidential power,” presenting his strongman approach as necessary given the socio-economic chaos he inherited (McFaul, 2021, p. 20). By 2008, Putin had purposefully developed a “highly managed democracy” in which “the formal democratic institutions lacked genuine autonomy and were incapable of impacting the state’s actions,” as his “personal power, unrestrained by institutions, coupled with the manipulation of public perception through mass media and controlled elections” allowed Putin to maintain complete political control (Prozorova, 2024, p. 1690). Thus, Putin utilized Russia’s instability to construct a competitive authoritarian regime, an idea supported by the arguments of Putin’s media control, political and social suppression, and centralized authority.

IV. Argument 1: Media Control

The first core argument for Putin’s competitive authoritarian regime centers on his control of the media. According to Levitsky and Way, having a robust media environment is key to maintaining a vibrant democracy, as it facilitates the exchange of oppositional voices and criticism necessary in the democratic process (2020, p. 60). Yet autocrats can create an ‘uneven’ playing field by censoring independent voices and using the media to push their own propaganda, while at the same time silencing dissenting voices. Similarly, Putin has tightened his grip on news outlets, independent journalists, and social media platforms over the past few decades in hopes of maintaining authority and political control. For example, during his first years as president, Putin “seized control over national television networks, understanding that these assets played an essential role in delivering electoral success” while also driving out media CEOs such as Boris Berezovsky, who “surrendered control of the country’s largest television network, ORT, to the Kremlin” (McFaul, 2021, p. 20). He primarily did this by using his

administrative authority to fund loyal media while also threatening and arresting anyone who resisted.

Today, Russian media “is controlled by the state or state-business elite” through managers that are financed by and loyal to the Kremlin, while independent “journalists have also developed sophisticated mechanisms of self-censorship” to comply with laws protecting the Kremlin (Alyukov, 2022, p. 337). This is because Putin has often “squashed independent media outlets, blacklisted journalists, and designated entities such as the Institute for Law and Public Policy, Radio Free Europe/Radio Liberty, Meduza, and the Insider as ‘foreign agents,’” opening them up for criminal investigation and imprisonment (McFaul, 2021, p. 23). Yet Putin’s media control goes beyond traditional news sources, as he has also heavily censored the online social media environment as well. For example, Putin’s “regime blocked dozens of websites, including those of Navalny and the human-rights association Team 29, Czech Radio’s Russian-language page, and the human-rights project Gulagu.net” while also banning Europe-based organizations such as “the Freedom of Information Society, Khodorkovsky Foundation, Oxford Russia Fund, Future of Russia Foundation, and European Choice” (McFaul, 2021, p. 23).

This is significant, as these groups are among the few entities capable of informing citizens of the reality of the regime. However, Putin has consistently justified his media suppression by claiming he is simply responding to “threats from the West, and the United States in particular, urging ‘vigilance’ against a CIA-orchestrated color revolution, which pro-Putin commentators claim was attempted” in Belarus (McFaul, 2021, p. 23). Putin’s media control has also resulted in the use of widespread propaganda campaigns to sway public opinion, as seen in the country’s invasion of Ukraine in 2022.

During the conflict, state media outlets reported that the invasion was simply a ‘special military operation’ meant to stop a genocide in the Donbas area and de-Nazify the region, despite it being a clear invasion (Alyukov, 2022, p. 344). This connects to a larger pattern in which citizens see that the “news about events in Russia is ‘window-dressing’” that covers up the truth while also attempting to push propaganda that “may tap into citizens’ patriotic feelings” and cultural heritage (Alyukov, 2022, p. 347). Russian media can thus “shape public perceptions by boosting certain developments, playing down others, or ignoring them altogether, and by praising or smearing certain figures or groups,” which is key in maintaining political control (Lipman, 2022, p. 181). This is a prime example of what Levitsky and Way describe as creating an ‘uneven playing field.’ In this case, Putin uses biased news media to make it “difficult for critical voices to reach large audiences,” while also pushing propaganda that justifies his political actions (Levitsky and Way, 2019, p. 2). While the media is an effective tool for Putin to control the spread of information, he also utilizes election rigging and the consolidation of centralized authority to keep control.

V. Argument 2: Electoral Manipulation and Political Centralization

A second argument for Putin’s competitive authoritarianism is his use of electoral

manipulation and the centralization of executive power. Democracies are built around elections that are “regular, free, and fair,” as they facilitate the transfer of power, signal shifting values, and allow citizens to voice their opinions (Prozorova, 2024, p. 1688). However, elections can also be twisted through rigging, as autocrats can use manipulated elections to justify their actions and legitimize their authority. According to Levitsky and Way, competitive authoritarian regimes often go about this by packing “judiciaries, electoral commissions and other nominally independent bodies to ensure that the incumbent will win critical electoral, legal or other disputes” while taking more power over time (2019, p. 2). In Russia, this phenomenon has been present since the Yeltsin era, yet Putin has taken this to a new level. Today, “multiparty elections are employed as a ‘strategy’ to preserve the existing status quo and secure the regime’s survival,” with “staged and manipulated” voting conducted by Kremlin-loyal electoral committee members (Prozorova, 2024, p. 1690). As a result, these elections are “uncompetitive and unfair,” meaning that they do not represent the average Russian and cannot bring about real political change in the country (Prozorova, 2024, p. 1690). For instance, independent Russian journalists and international organizations found “overwhelming evidence of fraud in the December 2011 parliamentary elections,” yet this did not result in any formal investigation or recount, which eventually triggered widespread protests across the country (McFaul, 2021, p. 21). Thus, these rigged elections allow Putin to consistently win elections, giving him ample opportunities to consolidate power through increased centralization.

Putin’s political centralization began in 2001, when he “forced the merger of some political parties to create United Russia (UR), which increasingly dominated the party system and elections” by establishing “a structure in whose name a government could be formed and through which legislation could be rammed through parliament” (Sakwa, 2022, p. 48). United Russia is the Kremlin’s primary way of holding power across the regional and national levels, and it has only grown in size and influence since its creation. For example, “in both the 2016 and 2021 Duma elections, UR retained a constitutional majority, with over two-thirds of the 450 seats” (Sakwa, 2022, p. 48). This legislative dominance gives Putin extraordinary power to pass the laws that expand his authority and influence. One example of Putin’s political centralization was in 2020, when “Putin proposed, and Russians ratified, constitutional amendments that further strengthened executive authority and would allow him to stay in power until 2036” (McFaul, 2021, p. 22). In this way, Putin has utilized Kremlin-loyalists within the United Russia party to remain in power despite clear constitutional limits. Additionally, his centralized authority has also weakened the opposition. For instance, “roughly nine million Russians are now ineligible to run for elected office as a result of recent changes to electoral laws” pushed by Putin (McFaul, 2021, p. 23). These developments closely fit what Levitsky and Way had in mind when discussing how competitive authoritarian regimes create an ‘uneven playing field.’ This is because Putin has successfully utilized staged elections to garner support while at the same time using the United Russia party to centralize his authority through close legislative influence. This aspect of Putin’s regime gives him the ability to enact sweeping legislative changes – and also punish his opposition through social, legal, and political suppression.

VI. Argument 3: Legal, Political, and Social Suppression

One final argument for Putin running a competitive authoritarian regime is through his legal, political, and social suppression. This is in line with what Levitsky and Way describe as the use of governmental power to “systematically deny the opposition access to crucial resources, media or state institutions” (Levitsky and Way, 2019, p. 1). In Russia, there is a clear “divergence” between the “formal constitutional order” and the “instrumental use of law and attempts to manage political processes by an administrative regime” that is primarily concerned with staying in power (Sakwa, 2022, p. 41). In other words, Russian democratic and legal institutions are often weaponized through biased officials and judges, who turn once-neutral institutions into instruments of oppression. For instance, in most “political cases, the judicial system is suborned,” and this “lack of judicial independence is particularly evident in ‘raiding’ attacks on business” leaders who pose a threat to Putin’s regime (Sakwa, 2022, p. 41). One prime example of this was in 2003, when the Russian government arrested oil CEO Mikhail Khodorkovsky for fraud charges (Sakwa, 2022, p. 42). However, this arrest was likely due to his funding of oppositional parties, but his company, Yukos, was still “dismembered, with most of the spoils going to the state-owned oil company, Rosneft” (Sakwa, 2022, p. 42). This development set a precedent, as it “not only ensured that business leaders stayed out of politics, but also brought the state back into the heart of business life” as the Kremlin used the “selective punishment of some elite sections and selective co-optation of others” to keep the rich supporting the government (Sakwa, 2022, p. 48). Putin uses this environment of fear and loyalty to keep influential citizens on his side.

Beyond economic pressure, Putin has also participated in social repression by fostering a deep divide between what he labels “conservative patriots and Western-funded traitors” (McFaul, 2021, p. 22). This ‘conflict’ has served as the foundation of much of Putin’s legislation, as it can be used to justify the social and political suppression of Russian citizens. For example, in 2012, Putin introduced new legislation to “crack down on civil society, increase control on Russians with dual citizenship, and label nongovernmental organizations receiving international donations as ‘foreign agents’” (McFaul, 2021, p. 22). Furthermore, Putin “effectively banned many rights and cultural symbols of the LGBT community” and pushed for “new legislation curtailing peaceful assembly and criminalizing participation in unsanctioned rallies” (McFaul, 2021, p. 22). In this way, Putin utilizes his control of legal and legislative institutions to keep Russian citizens in check and secure his hold on power.

Yet Putin’s most notorious form of suppression is his targeted attacks on political opponents. This is mainly done through poisonings, assassination attempts, and accusations of treason or espionage. A prime example of this is how Putin dealt with Alexei Navalny, a prominent political opposition leader who rose during Putin’s third term. After years of governmental intimidation and stalking, “Putin’s henchmen brazenly poisoned Navalny with a Novichok nerve agent” in August of 2020, and “he only survived by being medically evacuated to Germany” (McFaul, 2021, p. 23). However, Navalny refused to quit and was quickly arrested

upon his return to Russia “for the alleged crime of violating his parole by flying to Germany—unconscious, on a life support system” (McFaul, 2021, p. 23). From there, Navalny “was sentenced to an additional nine years for alleged fraud in his fundraising efforts and for insulting a judge,” yet these charges were “obviously without merit” and simply implemented “to keep Navalny in prison longer” (Slider, 2022, p. 26). The government labeled Navalny’s Foundation Against Corruption as an “extremist organization,” meaning that many “affiliated political leaders could therefore not participate in parliamentary elections” and had to flee Russia (McFaul, 2021, p. 23). On top of using physical assassination attempts to suppress political dissidents, the Russian government also utilizes coordinated hacking attacks to undermine opposition. For example, Navalny’s “‘smart voting’ internet site was the target of multiple DDoS attacks,” the Kremlin pushed communication networks to identify “all “smart voting” messages as spam” or block them, and forced Apple and Google to remove the ‘smart voting app’ from app stores” (Slider, 2022, p. 27). Ultimately, Putin’s tight control of the media, election rigging, centralization of legislative and executive authority, and his economic, social, and political suppression point to Russia being an autocratic regime according to Levitsky and Way. This is because all these factors contribute to an ‘uneven playing field’ in which Putin has significant power to shape laws, go after opponents, and create structural advantages to maintain control.

VII. Counterarguments

Despite this evidence, some still claim that Putin’s high approval ratings and Russia’s general stability point towards the country being closer to a democracy. This counterargument relies on the fact that most Russian citizens seem fine with Putin’s regime, as they appreciate having political order rather than the chaos that occurred under Yeltsin. However, high approval ratings do not necessarily point to a government being capable or stable. For example, “the enormously high presidential approval ratings in Russia may also result from the accessibility effect rather than genuine regime support” (Alyukov, 2022, p. 352). The accessibility effect happens when ideas that are “repeatedly emphasized in media” are often more “easily retrievable from memory” compared to opinions that require critical reflection and investigative research (Alyukov, 2022, p. 339). Because “Russian media have been paying disproportionate attention to international politics for years,” most polling responses are likely just repeating what citizens have heard instead of what they actually believe (Alyukov, 2022, p. 352). In other words, Russian polling might only be measuring surface-level opinions that are usually influenced by state-controlled propaganda, thus not providing an accurate representation of popular Russian opinion. Another problem with the polling counterargument is the fact that the Russian government consistently lies and fakes election results to maintain an image of control and order. Given their track record, it is reasonable to assume the official polling of the country may also be skewed or fabricated.

The second major counterargument for Russian democracy centers on the economic growth, political stability, and pluralism achieved during Putin’s first term. Some claim that these

positive developments signal the broader success of Russia's democratic institutions. Supporters of this idea usually point to Putin's early tax reforms, his use of Western-aligned economic and foreign-policy advisors, and Russia's growing export sectors (McFaul, 2021, p. 19). However, there are a few problems with this approach. This is because "the sources of his popularity" were "not entirely or even mostly" of Putin's design (McFaul, 2021, p. 19). For example, Russia's economic growth and rising oil prices were due to "structural economic factors" over which "Putin had no influence," as "they would have done the same for Nemtsov's popularity, or any other Russian leader in the right place at the right time in 2000" (McFaul, 2021, p. 19). As for the political stability achieved during Putin's first term, this was mainly a result of the implementation of a "managed democracy," wherein the formal democratic institutions lacked genuine autonomy and were incapable of impacting the state's actions" (Prozorova, 2024, p. 1690). In other words, while Russia presented itself as having a democratic system, the governmental institutions were simply too weak and ineffective to contain an autocrat like Putin. This closely fits with the idea that authoritarian regimes usually occur in states with weak governmental authority, as it creates an opportunity for a politician to consolidate power. Lastly, the pluralism seen in Russia under Putin only exists because "Putin was popular enough to win elections" without having to "completely crush all political opposition or debilitate every democratic institution" at first (McFaul, 2021, p. 20). Simply put, political pluralism never posed a real threat to Putin, as it could be eliminated at any moment. Again, this points to how the Russian government uses the veil of democracy to cover its autocratic leanings. Yet this image has diminished over time, as Putin is no "longer even pretending" to permit opposition and seems "to care little about condemnation from domestic or international critics, having arrested, banned, or chased into exile" even his "most marginal opponents in civil society and the media" (McFaul, 2021, p. 22). In other words, Putin's actions have brought the country away from its already weakened 'managed democratic' state.

VIII. Conclusion

In conclusion, analyzing autocracy in Russia is a complicated task that requires understanding Russian history, defining competitive authoritarianism, explaining the conditions that often lead to autocracy, and looking at how Putin's actions fit the label of an autocrat. Doing so reveals that, although Russia maintains the outward appearance of a democracy through its elections and court system, it effectively functions as an autocratic regime. This is because of Putin's tightening grip on media sources, electoral manipulation, the centralization of political and legislative authority, and the economic, social, and political suppression that dissidents and oppositional leaders face. Thus, the country fits several of the main indicators proposed by political scientists Steven Levitsky and Lucan Way, meaning that Putin's Russia can be classified as a competitive authoritarian regime due to the creation of an 'uneven playing field.' In today's increasingly globalized world, it is more important than ever to understand how autocrats take

power and contribute to democratic backsliding. Putin's tools of oppression are not unique to Russia, and other democracies must take heed.

IX. Connection to Law

The relevance of this research goes beyond simply describing Russia's current governmental system, as it highlights the broader patterns occurring worldwide of governments moving away from democracy and towards authoritarianism. By analyzing the various ways that competitive authoritarian regimes originate and function, this research reveals the deeper mechanisms that autocrats can use to maintain power and control. This is particularly important in today's global political environment, where democratic backsliding is found in all corners of the world, not just in Russia. Understanding the various methods leaders such as Vladimir Putin use to maintain power (like control of the media, electoral manipulation, political centralization, and legal, political, and social suppression) makes it easier to spot early warning signs of authoritarian behavior in other countries, as well. This is necessary because it can help policymakers and scholars alike push for change before democratic institutions are fully dismantled.

This research also connects to the rule of law. In democratic systems, the rule of law is meant to be independent and fair, protecting citizens' rights from governmental overreach. However, Vladimir Putin has abused and manipulated the justice system in Russia to suppress dissent, maintain power, and silence opposition. In this way, the Russian courts have effectively been transformed into an extension of Putin's political power. This abuse of the legal system further reinforces the need for vigilance and public awareness worldwide. Beyond legal matters, however, this analysis also demonstrates the importance of public awareness. When citizens understand how political and legal institutions can be used for good and bad, they are better prepared to engage critically and recognize when governmental institutions are being abused and undermined. Overall, this research contributes to a clearer understanding of how competitive authoritarian regimes function in the modern age while also reinforcing the need for institutional checks and balances, governmental accountability, and an informed civic base.

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Houthi Attacks in the Red Sea:

The Role of Missiles and Drones

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I. Houthi Attacks in the Red Sea: The Role of Missiles and Drones

The Houthi attacks in the Red Sea demonstrate that, while modern military technology did not fundamentally alter the political nature of the conflict, it significantly transformed the methods and scope of engagement. The underlying dynamics remained political: the Houthis sought to pressure Israel and its allies, attract international attention, and assert influence over a broader regional conflict. Conversely, the United States, the United Kingdom, and other external actors aimed to safeguard freedom of navigation, protect commercial shipping, and reestablish deterrence. These objectives were inherently political rather than technological. However, the introduction of missiles and drones altered the means by which these goals were pursued. A non-state actor lacking a conventional navy was able to threaten a critical global shipping route. Thus, technology did not supplant politics but amplified the reach of political objectives. In this context, modern technology primarily changed the conduct of the conflict by making it more cost-effective, rapid, disruptive, and difficult to manage.

The cause of the Red Sea crisis was connected to the wider war in Gaza after October 7, 2023, but it also came from the Houthis' own position in Yemen and the region. The Houthis had already become a powerful armed group in Yemen, and after the Gaza war began, they said their attacks were meant to support Palestinians and target ships tied to Israel or its allies (Reuters, 2024). This matters because the attacks were not random acts of violence at sea. They were meant to send a political message. The Red Sea and the Bab el-Mandeb Strait were useful places to do this because they are important shipping routes. The IMF explained that about 15 percent of global maritime trade volume normally passes through the Suez Canal route connected to the Red Sea (Kamali et al., 2024). By choosing this route, the Houthis could make a regional political issue into an international problem.

Still, the technology is what made this strategy possible. If the Houthis had needed a normal navy to challenge shipping in the Red Sea, the conflict would have looked very different. They would have had to build ships, train crews, and face stronger navies directly. Instead, they used anti-ship missiles and one-way attack drones from land. Weapons like the Qasef-1 drone, the Sayyad anti-ship cruise missile, and the Asif anti-ship ballistic missile gave them the ability to reach ships at long distances without meeting U.S. or British forces in a normal naval battle. The Wilson Center lists the Qasef-1 as having a flight distance of up to 200 kilometers, the Sayyad as having a range of up to 300 kilometers, and the Asif as having a range of up to 400 kilometers with a 500-kilogram payload (Wilson Center, 2024). These numbers matter because they show how a group on land could still affect what happened at sea.

This case exemplifies the concept of asymmetry, wherein a weaker actor does not need to match a stronger opponent directly but can instead employ less costly or unconventional methods to exert pressure. The Houthis could not defeat the U.S. Navy or the Royal Navy in confrontation, yet this was unnecessary. Through the use of missiles and drones, they compelled powerful states to allocate significant resources to the defense of commercial shipping. Additionally, they introduced uncertainty for shipping companies regarding the safety of the Red Sea. This supports

the argument that technology primarily altered the conduct of the conflict. While the political objective—coercion and pressure—remained traditional, the means were modern. Missiles and drones enabled a weaker actor to generate effects disproportionate to its conventional military strength.

The technology also changed the conflict by making disruption more important than destruction. In a traditional military fight, success is often measured by how much territory is taken or how many enemy forces are destroyed. In this case, the Houthis did not need to sink many ships to have an impact. The threat itself was enough to change behavior. Shipping companies rerouted vessels around the Cape of Good Hope, adding time and cost to global trade. The IMF reported that Suez Canal trade dropped by 50 percent in the first two months of 2024 compared with the year before, and that some shipping companies diverted ships around Africa, adding 10 days or more on average to delivery times (Kamali et al., 2024). That is one of the strongest examples of how modern technology shaped this case. The physical attacks mattered, but the fear and uncertainty around the attacks mattered too.

The Red Sea case also shows the salvo problem. In simple terms, the salvo problem is when a defender has to stop repeated incoming missiles or drones, and even one successful strike can cause serious damage. This creates a difficult situation for naval forces. Warships can have advanced radar, interceptors, and guns, but they still have to make decisions quickly. They have to detect the threat, classify it, and decide whether to fire. The attacker may be using cheaper systems, while the defender may be using expensive missiles or advanced systems to stop them. This does not mean the defender is weak. It means the defender is stuck with a harder cost and timing problem. If the Houthis launch multiple drones or missiles over time, the U.S. and its partners have to keep responding again and again.

The U.S. and U.K. response shows this clearly. The United Kingdom reported that HMS Diamond used its Sea Viper missile system to shoot down a Houthi missile targeting a merchant vessel in the Gulf of Aden, and that HMS Richmond had shot down two attack drones using Sea Ceptor missiles (Ministry of Defence, 2024). The same report said HMS Diamond had destroyed nine drones using Sea Viper and guns during earlier operations (Ministry of Defence, 2024). These details show that technology was not just on the Houthis' side. Outside powers also relied on advanced technology to defend ships and keep sea lanes open. But the key point is that the stronger side was often reacting. The Houthis could create a threat with missiles and drones, and the coalition had to intercept, patrol, and sometimes strike back.

This connects to deterrence. Deterrence is about convincing the other side that attacking is not worth the cost. In the Red Sea, the U.S., U.K., and partner forces tried to restore deterrence by intercepting attacks and striking Houthi launch sites. U.S. Central Command reported that on January 16, 2024, U.S. forces destroyed four Houthi anti-ship ballistic missiles that were prepared to launch because they presented an imminent threat to merchant and U.S. Navy ships (U.S. Central Command, 2024a). The next day, U.S. forces struck 14 Houthi missiles that were loaded to be fired from Houthi-controlled areas in Yemen (U.S. Central Command, 2024b). These strikes were meant to reduce the Houthis' ability to keep attacking and to show that

attacks would bring consequences. But deterrence did not work perfectly because the Houthis continued to threaten and attack shipping even after military responses.

That failure of perfect deterrence is important. It shows that military technology can punish or block attacks, but it does not automatically solve the political problem behind them. The Houthis had political reasons to continue. They could present themselves as part of a larger struggle over Gaza, and they could use U.S. and U.K. strikes as proof that they were confronting major powers. This is where politics and technology interact. The Houthis used missiles and drones for military disruption, but also for political messaging. The U.S. and U.K. used airstrikes and naval defense for military protection, but also to send a political message that freedom of navigation mattered. Each side used technology to communicate resolve, not just to hit targets.

The conflict also became harder to control because missiles and drones increased escalation risks. These weapons can be launched quickly, travel fast, and force immediate decisions. A missile or drone heading toward a ship may not leave much time to figure out the exact target or the broader intention behind the attack. This speed can create mistakes. It also pressures outside states to respond before they have full political control over the situation. If they respond too weakly, attacks may continue. If they respond too strongly, the conflict can widen. The United Nations Security Council seemed aware of this risk when it condemned the Houthis' attacks but also urged caution and restraint to avoid further escalation in the Red Sea and the broader region (United Nations Security Council, 2024).

For these reasons, technology did not fundamentally alter the nature of the conflict. The war remained inherently political. The Houthis employed drones and missiles not solely due to their availability, but because these weapons advanced their political objectives. Similarly, external powers deployed warships not merely because of technological capability, but because safeguarding trade routes and navigational rights constituted political and economic imperatives. Technology influenced the available options, yet politics determined the significance of those choices. This case supports the view that technology more frequently transforms the conduct of war than the underlying motivations for conflict.

At the same time, it would be too simple to say technology only changed the tools. In this case, technology also expanded the scale of the conflict. A local or regional actor in Yemen was able to affect shipping companies, sailors, insurance costs, naval deployments, and global trade. The International Maritime Organization condemned attacks against international shipping and emphasized that protecting seafarers, ships, and cargoes was a major concern (International Maritime Organization, 2024). The UN Security Council also condemned at least two dozen Houthi attacks on merchant and commercial vessels since November 19, 2023, and said these attacks impeded global commerce and undermined navigational rights and freedoms (United Nations Security Council, 2024). That shows the conflict was no longer only about Yemen or Gaza. It became a maritime security crisis.

Another part of this case is technological adaptation. Neither side stayed the same. The Houthis adjusted by using a mix of drones, cruise missiles, and ballistic missiles. That made defense harder because each system could create a different kind of threat. A drone might be

slower and cheaper, while a ballistic missile can move faster and give defenders less time. Coalition forces adapted by using air defense, surveillance, interceptors, and strikes on launch sites. This back and forth matters because modern war is not just about who has the best weapon at the beginning. It is about who adapts faster as the other side changes. The Red Sea shows that even when advanced states can shoot down many incoming threats, they still have to keep adapting to a cheaper and more persistent threat.

There is also an ethical side to this case. Civilian crews and commercial ships became part of a military and political struggle they did not control. The Houthis claimed their campaign was aimed at ships connected to Israel or its allies, but in practice, the danger spread across a much wider shipping environment. Commercial sailors from many countries faced risks from missiles, drones, and rerouting. The IMO's focus on seafarer safety shows that the human part of this case cannot be ignored (International Maritime Organization, 2024). This matters because modern technology can make it easier to attack targets from a distance, but distance can also make the effects feel less direct to the attacker. The people on the ships still face the consequences.

The case also shows that modern military technology can create political leverage without producing a clear military victory. The Houthis did not defeat the U.S., the U.K., or their partners. They also did not gain control over the Red Sea. But they did create pressure. They forced rerouting, drew international attention, triggered UN action, and made major powers commit resources to a defensive mission. That is a type of success for a weaker actor because the goal was not to win a traditional battle. The goal was to make the conflict costly and visible. This is why missiles and drones are so important in modern war. They give weaker actors a way to compete through disruption.

In summary, the Houthi attacks in the Red Sea illustrate the interconnectedness of technology and politics, while emphasizing their distinct roles. Political objectives remained primary: the Houthis sought to exert pressure and gain leverage, while external actors prioritized protection, deterrence, and the maintenance of open sea lanes. Modern missiles and drones altered the pursuit of these goals by increasing asymmetry, disruption, and the difficulty of containment. These technologies enabled a non-state actor to challenge global trade without possessing a conventional navy. Ultimately, modern military technology primarily transformed the conduct of the conflict and expanded its impact, making it appear larger than the initial political dispute. The Red Sea case demonstrates that contemporary warfare involves not only the destruction of adversaries but also the creation of uncertainty, escalation of costs, influence over decision-making, and the provocation of political responses across a broader system.

II. Connection to Law

This research connects to law because the Red Sea crisis is not only a military issue, but also a legal and political issue. The attacks on commercial ships raise questions about freedom of navigation, maritime security, and the legal protection of civilian shipping. In this case, the Houthis used missiles and drones to pressure Israel and its allies, but the effects went beyond the

original political message. Commercial sailors, shipping companies, and global trade became part of the conflict even though they were not the main actors. This matters because international law has to protect sea lanes, but it also has to respond carefully when attacks come from a non-state actor. The legal issue becomes more difficult because the Houthis did not need a normal navy to affect the Red Sea. Their use of drones and missiles allowed them to threaten ships from land, which makes enforcement harder for outside powers. The United States, the United Kingdom, and other actors responded by defending ships, intercepting weapons, and striking Houthi launch sites. This connects to the law of armed conflict because states have to decide when force is legally justified, how much force is proportional, and how to prevent the conflict from spreading. If states respond too weakly, the attacks may continue. If they respond too strongly, the crisis can widen. This paper shows that modern military technology creates legal challenges because it gives weaker actors the ability to disrupt global systems without winning a traditional war. The law must deal with more than direct attacks. It must also deal with fear, rerouting, economic costs, escalation risks, and the safety of civilians at sea. Overall, this research matters because it shows how international law and maritime policy must adapt when drones and missiles make regional conflicts affect global trade and security.

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The Fragile Progress of Organized Labor

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I. The Fragile Progress of Organized Labor

The Industrial Union Manifesto of 1905 stated that when modern workers stopped producing maximum profits, they were often discarded like useless machinery. This era of rapid industrialization showed human skills being replaced by machinery and growing economic power among wealthy industrialists, who were referred to as “Robber Barons” (Fink, 2014). Organized labor had a significant but inconsistent impact on improving the status of the working class. Through its “prudential unionism” strategy, the American Federation of Labor (AFL) helped gain economic stability for many skilled workers, but the government’s repression of strikes, racial and gender divisions, and the de-skilling effects of scientific management limited the broader labor movement (Laurie, 1989). This period is historically important because it revealed the tension between craft unionism and more radical industrial unionism, which showed that labor’s progress remained fragile without broader worker solidarity (Faue, 2017). This essay will analyze the Industrial Workers of the World’s (IWW) efforts to organize a broader working class, the AFL’s economic strategies, and the internal and external forces that ultimately limited the success of organized labor.

The AFL used the strategy of “prudential unionism,” which focused on achieving immediate economic gains for skilled workers rather than pursuing radical social reforms to deal with the anti-union environment of the Gilded Age (Laurie, 1989). In his Senate testimony, Adolph Strasser, who was a union leader, explained this philosophy by saying that the movement had “no ultimate ends” and it was focused on goals that could be achieved within a few years (Strasser, 1883). The eight-hour workday was one of the main goals of this approach that he argued would both improve workers’ lives and increase their ability to consume goods such as better housing, clothing, and education (Laurie, 1989). The AFL also relied on “benefit unionism,” by collecting high membership dues that funded strike reserves and gave workers health or unemployment benefits, to keep things stable during economic recessions (Laurie, 1989). These strategies helped many skilled workers achieve greater financial security and social stability while also helping unions survive economic depressions.

While the AFL focused primarily on the “labor aristocracy,” the IWW and other radical activists wanted to improve the social status of the entire working class. So they organized unskilled immigrants and women through industrial unionism (Faue, 2017). According to the 1905 Industrial Union Manifesto, traditional craft divisions were “artificial distinctions” that made it harder for workers to resist capitalist power because machines were replacing human skill very rapidly (Industrial Union Manifesto, 1905). The IWW promoted the idea of “one great industrial union”, built on the principle that “an injury to one is an injury to all,” rather than separating workers by trade (Industrial Union Manifesto, 1905).

This strategy helped unite workers from many different backgrounds during the 1912 Lawrence “Bread and Roses” strike, which saw over 25,000 textile workers from dozens of ethnic groups protest wage cuts (Faue, 2017). Their success showed that industrial unionism could improve the social status of immigrant workers because it could bring attention to their

working conditions and demands for dignity. Also, radical immigrant activists helped expand labor organizing. In cities such as Paterson and New York, Italian immigrant women like Maria Roda formed “Women’s Emancipation Groups” that used newspapers, public speeches, and social theater to mobilize workers and challenge the idea that women were incapable of political activism (Guglielmo, 2010). These women used the radical press and “Teatro Sociale” (social theatre) to reach illiterate audiences and spread a vision of freedom that extended beyond the factory floor (Guglielmo, 2010). This broadened the scope of organized labor by including groups that had often been excluded from traditional unions.

Organized labor’s progress was also limited by internal divisions that prevented workers from forming a unified movement. Strong anti-Chinese rhetoric was promoted by labor leaders like Denis Kearney, who argued that Asian migrants were “cheap working slaves” who threatened white workers’ status and wages (Kearney, 1878). Employers were able to use excluded groups as strikebreakers and weaken labor organizing because of this nativist mindset, which led many white workers to see racial minorities as competitors rather than allies (Faue, 2017). Although the AFL often spoke about worker solidarity, many of its member unions maintained “white-only” membership policies that excluded Black workers and many immigrants (Laurie, 1989). Women also faced discrimination within the labor movement, because many unions treated them as temporary workers or dependents rather than equal participants in industrial labor. Because of these racial, ethnic, and gender divisions, it was difficult for organized labor to unite the entire working class, which ultimately limited its ability to improve the status of workers (Industrial Union Manifesto, 1905).

Organized labor faced strong external opposition from corporations, courts, and government authorities. One major challenge was the rise of scientific management, developed by Fredrick Winslow Taylor, which allowed managers to observe, analyze, and standardize tasks to increase efficiency and production (Thompson, 1917). This system broke jobs into small tasks, which reduced the need for skilled labor and weakened the traditional control that craftsmen had over their work. When labor conflicts did occur, government authorities usually intervened on behalf of employers (Laurie, 1989). For example, the 1892 Homestead Strike was broken after thousands of National Guard troops were deployed to protect strikebreakers and restore company control (Faue, 2017).

In a similar way, the federal government sent troops and issued court injunctions to put an end to the Pullman Strike in 1894, claiming the need to protect mail delivery. Courts also regularly issued labor injunctions to limit picketing and hold unions financially responsible for strike-related damages (Fink, 2014). The combination of corporate power, government intervention, and legal restrictions made it extremely difficult for organized labor to maintain its gains, leaving improvements in workers’ status fragile and easily reversed.

In conclusion, between 1875 and 1925, the American working class faced the difficult realities of industrial capitalism. Organized labor made a lot of progress, specifically through the AFL’s ability to secure higher wages and improved conditions for many skilled workers. At the same time, more radical movements, such as the IWW, attempted to expand the labor struggle to

include immigrants, women, and unskilled workers (Laurie, 1989). However, the movement's overall success was limited by internal divisions and the powerful opposition of corporations, courts, and government authorities (Industrial Union Manifesto, 1905). These challenges prevented organized labor from achieving broad improvements for the entire working class. Regardless, the struggles of this period raised awareness of workers' rights and laid important foundations for the labor reforms that would occur later in the twentieth century (Fraser, 1989).

II. Connection to Law

This paper is relevant to modern societal and legal issues because it examines the historical struggles between workers, corporations, and government power during the rise of industrial capitalism. Many of the same issues discussed in the essay continue to affect our society today, including workers' rights, wage inequality, unionization efforts, discrimination in the workplace, and the relationship between labor and the law. This paper shows how organized labor attempted to improve working conditions, secure fair wages, and protect workers from exploitation, while corporations and government institutions often resisted these efforts through legal restrictions, court injunctions, and the use of state power.

The discussion of scientific management and the replacement of skilled labor with machinery also connects directly to current concerns and automation, artificial intelligence, and job insecurity. In today's society, many workers fear that advancing technology may reduce job opportunities or weaken employee bargaining power in similar ways. In addition, the essay's analysis of racial and gender divisions within labor movements remains relevant because workplace inequality and discrimination are still major societal concerns. Modern labor laws, anti-discrimination protections, and workplace safety regulations were influenced by the labor struggles discussed in this paper.

Legally, the essay demonstrated how government intervention shaped labor relations through strikes, injunctions, and the protection of corporate interests. These historical conflicts contributed to later labor reforms and the development of laws involving collective bargaining, union protections, workplace safety, and workers' rights. The paper also highlights the importance of solidarity and equal representation within social movements, which remains significant in discussions about economic inequality and labor injustice today. Overall, this essay is relevant because it connects historical labor struggles to ongoing debates about fairness, corporate power, labor protections, and the role of government in regulating the workplace.

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**The Relationship Between Repeated Cyberbullying Exposure and Depression in High
School Students**

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I. Abstract

Cyberbullying has become one of the most serious online risks teenagers face today, often leading to emotional distress and mental health challenges. Research shows that teens who are cyberbullied frequently report higher levels of depression, anxiety, and difficulty focusing on school. However, most studies measure only the presence of cyberbullying rather than the frequency or repetition of victimization. This study aims to better understand how the frequency of cyberbullying relates to the severity of depressive symptoms among adolescents ages 15–18. Using an explanatory, non-experimental design, the study will measure how often students experience cyberbullying using the Cyberbullying Victimization Scale and assess depression with the PHQ-9A (Johnson et al., 2002). Two hundred adolescents from Detroit-area high schools will participate. It is expected that students who experience cyberbullying more frequently will report higher levels of depression. Understanding this relationship can help schools and families create stronger prevention strategies and earlier support for teens' mental health.

II. The Relationship Between Repeated Cyberbullying Exposure and Depression in High School Students

The digital age has turned cyberbullying into a significant problem for adolescents, creating long-term risks for their emotional and psychological well-being. Cyberbullying is defined as the intentional use of digital communication tools, including texting, social media, and online gaming, to harm or distress another person (Kowalski & Limber, 2013). Because it can happen at any time and in any online space, victims often feel they have no safe place to escape the harassment. Research consistently shows that adolescents who experience cyberbullying report higher levels of anxiety, depression, and lower self-esteem (Agatston et al., 2007; Sengupta & Chaudhuri, 2011). Frequent social media use has also been linked to greater chances of both being cyberbullied and taking part in cyberbullying behaviors (Mesch, 2009; Gohal et al., 2023). Although these harmful effects are well supported in the literature, there are still important gaps in understanding how the frequency or repetition of cyberbullying affects long-term outcomes. The present proposal focuses on two key areas: the psychological consequences of cyberbullying and the personal and environmental risk factors that make adolescents more vulnerable. Together, these themes highlight the need for continued research to better understand and reduce the harms associated with cyberbullying.

III. Literature Review

Cyberbullying's Psychological Effects on Adolescents

Cyberbullying has become a major concern because it directly disrupts adolescents' emotional functioning and contributes to lasting psychological harm. When adolescents experience cyberbullying, they often face repeated harassment that can be shared publicly and

persist online, amplifying distress (Kowalski & Limber, 2013). Research shows that victimized adolescents frequently report increased anxiety, sadness, and hopelessness, which can weaken academic motivation and overall school engagement (Kowalski & Limber, 2013). Because online content can be revisited or reshared, many teens relive distressing experiences outside of school, preventing emotional recovery.

Studies also show that cyberbullying undermines self-esteem and damages social relationships. Agatston et al. (2007) found that victims often experience social isolation and feelings of powerlessness because harmful messages can circulate widely across platforms. Many adolescents avoid reporting cyberbullying due to fears that adults may restrict internet use or misinterpret the situation, which increases emotional withdrawal. Sengupta and Chaudhuri (2011) further noted that gender shapes emotional responses: girls tend to internalize distress through anxiety and avoidance, while boys more often respond externally through anger or retaliation. Together, these findings show that cyberbullying has consistent negative psychological consequences, although specific emotional reactions differ among individuals. Across these studies, the most consistently reported psychological outcomes include heightened anxiety, depressive symptoms, reduced self-esteem, and emotional withdrawal, indicating that cyberbullying has broad and persistent effects on adolescents' mental well-being.

Further research highlights factors that intensify psychological harm. Adolescents who spend extensive time online without parental monitoring tend to experience increased loneliness and decreased trust following cyberbullying (Mesch, 2009). Gohal et al. (2023) found that repeated harassment contributes to chronic stress, sleep difficulties, and reduced academic motivation. Although studies agree that cyberbullying harms adolescents, most rely on single-time self-report surveys, limiting understanding of how psychological effects progress. More longitudinal research is needed to examine how repeated exposure influences the severity and duration of psychological symptoms.

Factors That Increase the Risk of Cyberbullying

Understanding what makes adolescents more vulnerable to cyberbullying is essential for developing effective prevention strategies. Research has identified several personal, social, and environmental factors that increase the likelihood of involvement. Frequent online activity, especially on social networking sites, significantly raises the risk of both becoming a victim and participating in cyberbullying (Mesch, 2009). Teens who share personal information online or interact with strangers without supervision face even greater risk. Kowalski and Limber (2013) also found that the anonymity of online communication can encourage aggressive behavior that adolescents might not show in person. Adolescents who feel socially isolated or who frequently seek validation online may be especially vulnerable to getting involved in cyberbullying.

Personal characteristics also play an important role. Sengupta and Chaudhuri (2011) found that low self-control, impulsivity, and weak social skills are linked to higher chances of both perpetrating and experiencing cyberbullying. Gender differences also appear in the research, with boys more likely to engage in cyberbullying and girls more likely to experience it.

Environmental factors can intensify these risks. Agatston et al. (2007) found that students who attend schools they perceive as unsafe or unsupportive are less likely to report cyberbullying, which allows harmful behaviors to continue.

A major concern noted by Gohal et al. (2023) is that many adolescents do not receive enough guidance on digital citizenship or safe online behavior. Without proper support, they may overshare information, misinterpret online boundaries, or react aggressively when conflicts arise. The risk becomes even higher when parental monitoring is limited or when students lack digital literacy education. Although research has been consistent in identifying who is most at risk, many studies rely on short-term self-report data, making it difficult to understand how these risk factors change over time. More research is needed to examine how multiple risk factors interact and how prevention efforts, such as digital literacy programs, parental involvement, and supportive school environments, can help lower adolescents' vulnerability to cyberbullying.

Conclusions and Rationale

Current literature shows that cyberbullying creates significant psychological consequences for adolescents, including anxiety, depression, social withdrawal, and reduced academic motivation (Kowalski & Limber, 2013; Agatston et al., 2007). Studies also show that risk increases among adolescents who spend extensive time online, have limited parental oversight, or attend schools with unsupportive climates (Mesch, 2009; Sengupta & Chaudhuri, 2011). These findings demonstrate that adolescents' emotional well-being is closely tied to their online experiences and that both personal vulnerabilities and digital environments contribute to harmful psychological outcomes.

However, significant gaps remain. Although existing studies identify emotional consequences, they rarely examine how these emotions change or persist over time, making it difficult to understand patterns of recovery or worsening symptoms. Most research examines whether cyberbullying occurs rather than the frequency or duration of exposure, and few studies investigate whether repeated exposure amplifies psychological harm. Additionally, much of the literature relies on single-time self-reports, limiting insight into how emotional impacts develop or intensify among adolescents who already possess known risk factors. Understanding repeated exposure is crucial for developing more targeted prevention and early intervention approaches. These gaps lead to the central problem: the field lacks research examining how the frequency of cyberbullying exposure relates to the severity of depressive symptoms in adolescents.

Proposed Research

Research has shown that cyberbullying contributes to serious psychological consequences in adolescents, including higher levels of depression and lower academic performance. Kowalski and Limber (2013) found that adolescents who experienced cyberbullying reported significantly greater depressive symptoms and poorer academic outcomes compared to those who were not bullied. Similarly, Gohal et al. (2023) found that frequent online

harassment increased the risk of depression among youth, particularly those who used social media daily. However, much of the existing research has focused only on whether cyberbullying occurs, rather than how often adolescents experience it. This leaves a critical gap in understanding whether sustained exposure to cyberbullying intensifies depressive symptoms over time, despite strong theoretical evidence suggesting that repeated stressors can have cumulative effects on mental health. Accordingly, this study examines the question: How does six-month cyberbullying frequency relate to depressive symptom severity in adolescents?

The present study aims to address this gap by examining how the frequency of cyberbullying exposure across six months relates to depressive symptom severity among high school adolescents aged 15 to 18 who are active on social media. This study uses an explanatory approach, focusing on understanding the relationship between cyberbullying frequency and depressive symptoms rather than predicting future outcomes. Unlike prior research that measured only the presence of cyberbullying, this study will focus on the duration and repetition of exposure, offering a more precise view of how ongoing online victimization affects psychological well-being. By exploring the connection between repeated cyberbullying and depression, this research seeks to deepen understanding of how persistent digital stressors influence adolescent mental health, an area that remains underexplored in current literature. It is hypothesized that adolescents, aged 15-18, who experience higher frequencies of cyberbullying over six months will report significantly higher levels of depression than those who experience little or no cyberbullying. This prediction reflects a positive association between cyberbullying exposure and depressive symptom severity, with both variables measured using validated survey instruments to ensure accuracy and replicability.

IV. Proposed Method

Previous studies on cyberbullying have largely focused on whether adolescents experience online harassment, but have not fully explored how the frequency and duration of those experiences influence mental health outcomes. The present study extends this work by investigating how repeated exposure to cyberbullying during the past six months relates to depressive symptoms among high school students aged 15 to 18. Using a non-experimental, explanatory design, this research will examine the natural relationship between how often adolescents experience cyberbullying and the severity of their depressive symptoms. By focusing on patterns of repeated exposure, this study aims to provide a more comprehensive understanding of how ongoing online victimization affects adolescent well-being. The following sections describe the participants, materials, and procedures in greater detail.

V. Participants

In this study, 200 high school students aged 15 to 18 years will participate. The sample will include adolescents of all genders and diverse racial and socioeconomic backgrounds. Eligibility requires current enrollment in high school and daily use of at least one social media

platform (for example, Instagram, TikTok, or Snapchat). Adolescents with diagnosed severe mental illnesses will be excluded to prevent confounding effects on depression scores. Severe pre-existing mental illness may independently elevate depressive symptoms, making it difficult to isolate the specific relationship between cyberbullying exposure and depression for this study.

Participants will be recruited from four to five public and charter high schools in the Detroit metropolitan area. A stratified random sampling method will be used to ensure balanced representation across gender and school type. Recruitment will occur through the help of school counseling offices, their advisors, and online parent communication systems. Following Bauman, Cross, and Walker (2013), careful attention will be given to minimizing sampling bias by recording nonresponse rates and ensuring that schools are demographically diverse.

Active parental consent and student assent will be obtained for participants aged 15 to 17, while students who are 18 years old will provide their own informed consent with parental notification. The consent forms will clearly describe the study's purpose, procedures, potential risks, and confidentiality protections. Participation will be voluntary, and students may withdraw at any time without penalty. Data will be collected anonymously, stored on an encrypted password-protected server, and accessible only to the research team. No compensation will be provided.

VI. Materials

Two validated self-report instruments will be used to measure the study variables. Cyberbullying exposure will be assessed using the Cyberbullying Victimization Scale (CVS; Patchin & Hinduja, 2010), a 10-item self-report measure that evaluates the frequency of online harassment behaviors such as exclusion, rumor spreading, and hurtful messages over the past six months. Responses are recorded on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (Never) to 5 (Very Often). An example item includes, "Someone posted a mean or hurtful comment about me online." The CVS has demonstrated excellent internal consistency reliability ($\alpha = .87$; Patchin & Hinduja, 2010).

Depression will be measured using the Patient Health Questionnaire for Adolescents (PHQ-9A; Johnson et al., 2002), a 9-item instrument assessing depressive symptoms experienced over the previous two weeks. Items are rated on a 4-point scale from 0 (Not at all) to 3 (Nearly every day). An example item includes, "I felt little interest or pleasure in doing things." Total scores range from 0 to 27, with higher scores indicating greater depression severity. The PHQ-9A demonstrates high reliability ($\alpha = .89$) and strong validity in adolescent samples (Johnson et al., 2002).

All measures will be administered through Qualtrics, a secure online survey platform that ensures confidentiality and data protection. Surveys will be completed in students' classrooms or school computer labs during scheduled advisory periods. Both instruments are well-supported by previous research and are commonly used in studies examining cyberbullying and adolescent mental health (Kowalski & Limber, 2013; Gohal et al., 2023).

VII. Procedure

This study will use a non-experimental, explanatory design to explore how often students experience cyberbullying over the past six months and how that relates to their levels of depression. The explanatory variable will be the frequency of cyberbullying exposure, and the criterion variable will be the depression level. This approach is appropriate because it allows the researcher to study relationships that cannot be ethically manipulated (Crano, Brewer, & Lac, 2015). Following Bauman, Cross, and Walker's (2013) recommendations for sound research practice, the procedure is designed to be clear, replicable, and ethically responsible.

Once approval is obtained from school administrators and consent is collected from parents and students, participants will receive a secure link to the Qualtrics survey. When they open the survey, they will first read an assent statement explaining the study's purpose, their rights, and the voluntary nature of participation. The survey is expected to take about 15–20 minutes to complete. Students will then answer short demographic questions about their age, gender, grade level, and social media use before completing two questionnaires: the Cyberbullying Victimization Scale (CVS) and the Patient Health Questionnaire for Adolescents (PHQ-9A). The order will be the same for everyone, beginning with the assent form, then demographics, followed by the CVS and PHQ-9A (Patchin & Hinduja, 2010; Johnson et al., 2002).

All responses will be submitted electronically and kept completely anonymous. Data will be stored on a password-protected, encrypted server that only the research team can access. The survey will remain open for four weeks during the winter semester, and a single reminder will be sent halfway through the collection period. Once the data are collected, Pearson's correlation coefficient (r) will be used to analyze the strength and direction of the relationship between cyberbullying exposure and depression levels, with a p -value below .05 indicating statistical significance. Ethical standards will be followed at every step to ensure students' safety, privacy, and the voluntary nature of participation.

VIII. Connection to Law

Cyberbullying is no longer a small problem that only affects a few students. It has grown into one of the biggest public health and legal challenges of the digital age. The research proposed in this paper speaks directly to a societal issue that touches nearly every adolescent today: the strong connection between repeated online harassment and serious mental health struggles, especially depression. As social media use keeps climbing among teenagers, the emotional toll of cyberbullying has caught the attention of parents, teachers, counselors, lawmakers, and mental health professionals across the country.

From a societal perspective, cyberbullying puts the emotional growth and academic future of millions of teens at risk. The students most affected often come from urban or under-resourced school districts, like many of those in the Detroit metropolitan area, where this study will take place. These same students frequently have the least access to mental health

support. When repeated cyberbullying goes unaddressed, depressive symptoms can deepen, school performance can drop, and existing social inequalities can widen. This study focuses on how often and how long adolescents experience cyberbullying rather than just whether it happened, which gives prevention programs and school counselors the kind of detailed information they actually need to build stronger and more targeted support systems.

Legally, cyberbullying sits in a complicated space. There is no single federal law in the United States that directly makes cyberbullying a crime. However, most states have passed legislation requiring schools to create and enforce anti-bullying policies that include online harassment. In Michigan, where this study is based, the Matt Epling Safe School Law of 2011 requires all school districts to maintain anti-bullying policies and document incidents when they occur. When cyberbullying involves threats, stalking, or sustained harassment, broader federal and state criminal statutes can come into play as well.

Even with these laws in place, enforcement is often inconsistent. Schools regularly struggle to respond to behavior that happens off campus or after school hours, and First Amendment protections make it harder to discipline students for online speech. Courts have wrestled with how to balance free expression with a school's responsibility to keep students safe. The Supreme Court's decision in *Mahanoy Area School District v. B.L.* in 2021 highlighted this tension when the Court ruled that schools generally cannot punish off-campus speech, though it allowed narrow exceptions for serious disruptions. Because of this legal gray area, many young victims of cyberbullying have very few formal options when seeking help, which makes research like this study even more important. Clear evidence shows how repeated exposure to cyberbullying damages mental health and can shape future legislation, guide court decisions, and push schools to expand the mental health resources available to students.

The findings of this proposed study could reach well beyond academic journals. By showing a clearer link between cyberbullying frequency and depression severity, this research can help lawmakers strengthen school safety policies, support advocacy groups working to hold online platforms accountable, and assist clinicians in identifying adolescents who need early intervention. Cyberbullying is not just a school problem or a parenting problem. It is a public health issue, an equity issue, and a legal responsibility that society can no longer afford to overlook.

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Influences of Politics on Irish and American Music

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I. Introduction

Music has long been a vehicle for emerging political ideas and opposition. Given that music is often used as a means of expression and to spread awareness, many genres throughout history have taken it upon themselves to convey political messages. More specifically, Ireland and the United States have employed music as an opposition to political oppression, using it to unite those who have faced injustice. It was brought to my attention how prevalent this type of music was in both countries after staying in Dublin. While sitting in restaurants, browsing stores, or walking around the city, I regularly heard a mixture of American alternative rock and country, both of which are regularly politically-charged. While there are many examples of how governance has impacted the American and Irish music scene, the focus of this research is on two genres that originated from their respective countries: American punk rock and Irish traditional music. Both styles of music have been used to combat oppression and inspire revolution for decades, if not longer, in response to government corruption. Additionally, both scenes influenced one another during periods of economic and political tension, bringing awareness to the struggles of the originating nation while also supporting the struggles of the one it inspired.

II. The Birth of Irish Traditional Music and Punk Rock

Irish traditional music itself is historical, with its origins dating back thousands of years. However, it has had many resurgences throughout history to allow it to remain as culturally significant as it is today. When describing the significance of Irish traditional music in opposition to Irish oppression, Morgenstern states in his article that a large number of the more rebellious songs were produced during the late eighteenth century and onwards. These songs were created as a plea for Irish independence from British colonial control, encouraging men of that era to aspire and fight for their own freedom (123). Moving forward, Irish traditional music experienced significant development in the 1970s, according to Kearny and Commins, as Ireland's economy was becoming more expansive due to Ireland's recent recruitment into the European Economic Community. This opportunity granted Irish traditional music more radio time, allowing the style to develop dramatically (254).

Furthermore, the punk rock scene in the United States began in the early 1970s. Finding its roots in cities like New York, bands such as The Ramones were pioneers of the newly emerging style (Brown 2). Despite New York being somewhat the birthplace of punk rock, the scene found its way primarily through smaller towns and suburbs in attempts to dodge the music industry (Brown 3).

III. Globalization and the Spread of Music

Following the revival or development of either genre of music, both managed to find their way into the other nation. Regarding Irish folk music, the genre traveled during a period of

mass immigration to the United States. The potato famine threatened the Irish population during the 1840s and 1850s, prompting a significant number of Irish individuals to find survival and work within the United States (Wells and Smith 395). As Irish immigration proceeded, many individuals incorporated their musical knowledge into American society in an attempt to build a community of familiarity in an unknown country (Wells and Smith 396). Major cities thus began to adopt the Irish traditional style, including New York, Boston, Chicago, and other locations beyond the typical settling points of the Irish people (Kearny and Commings 253). From here, American musicians adapted and modified the style of this genre, and these renditions became so popular that many Irish musicians began to adjust their original style to these new approaches (Wells and Smith 397).

IV. The Motives Behind Irish Traditional Music

As its popularity became increasingly apparent, so did its political message. Irish traditional artists, including Siamsa Tíre, The Chieftains, and the Siamsa Céilí Band, toured the United States during the same period that the Troubles occurred. This hardship impacted even the apolitical bands, conveying to the American fanbases they had accumulated that the Irish were in need (Kearny and Commings 258). At this time, other traditional artists began to use their concerts in the United States as fundraisers, gathering money to send to Northern Ireland for humanitarian relief. These attempts at providing for the Irish people promote the idea that Irish traditional music stood for Irish nationalism and independence (Kearny and Commings 258). This genre did not solely garner attention for the violence against the Irish during the Troubles, however, as it also brought attention to the necessity of affordable travel to promote awareness and the spread of culture (Kearny and Commings 260).

V. Themes Presented in Punk Rock

Concerning American punk rock, the scene was born from an initial, overarching message of rebellion and disobedience (Brown 2). While this theme presented itself in a variety of ways as punk's popularity began to grow, its primary representation was inherently political. Many artists promoted topics such as anarchism, anticapitalism, and justice for the oppressed (Brown 3). While punk rock emerged in the United States, it quickly found its way into the United Kingdom in the mid 1970s, resonating especially with the people of Northern Ireland. Those impacted by the Troubles found comfort or meaning in the messages promoted by punk rock, as the oppressed voices of those who created the music well represented the more modern struggles of those facing violence and British control (Martínez 195). Artists from the United Kingdom, such as the Sex Pistols, encapsulated the struggles of Northern Irish people in songs like "Anarchy in the UK." (Martínez 204). It became clear in Ireland that the punk scene was purposed with providing the truth that mass narratives masking violence and political corruption in Ireland were misleading, and the true colors of mainstream politics were far more problematic (Martínez 207).

VI. Comparisons

Both Irish traditional music and American punk rock represent very similar ideologies of defending the oppressed, rebelling against oppressive governments, and an overall desire to spread awareness of a nation's current political climate beyond what mainstream media claims. Both became culturally relevant during the early to mid 1970s, when the Troubles were highly active and inciting mass violence in Northern Ireland over the struggle for independence. Irish traditional music was amplified during this time and written to bring attention to these struggles and advocate for those harmed by riots and brutality. American punk music, while written in response to the political and economic state of the United States, as well as the corruption of the music industry, applied to the condition that Northern Ireland fell under. Because punk was already emerging in London, it found its way into Northern Ireland and promoted rebellion against persecution. While both music scenes were popular at the same time and promoted similar messages, there are key differences between the two. Irish national music had existed for millennia prior.

While it was used for political stances, it could also primarily be apolitical. Traditional music was also heavily geared towards honoring Ireland and its culture. Punk emerged with the intention of being political, given that the goal was to reject all that was considered mainstream. Punk, while it produced an identity of outcasts, had no sense of nationalism and did not typically honor the United States. Most times, punk music was used to criticize the American system. Despite these differences, both were able to support similar ideologies that allowed Americans to appreciate and sympathize with the Irish, and vice versa.

VII. Conclusion

Music has been a form of expression for individuals' plight for centuries. Ireland and the United States have demonstrated effective examples of this, specifically through Irish traditional music and American punk music. Both presented themes of representing the oppressed, challenging controlling authority, and establishing an identity. Traditional music stands for Irish nationalism, expressing pride in Irish identity and using it to advocate for independence and justice. Punk strongly represents rebellion, and while its community is divisive, this is often expressed through anti-government, anti-capitalist narratives. While these messages were initially intended for the nation they originated in, the United States and Ireland found resonance and empowerment through each other's music. This sharing and application of music emphasizes the importance of experiencing and embracing other cultures in order to garner sympathy and form a mutual connection over a nation's struggles. Music is a political tool, empowering artists to spread awareness of issues from any background.

VIII. Connection to Law

The interconnectedness of music and law becomes evident when examining how both Irish traditional music and American punk rock serve as conduits for political expression and social justice. Both genres arise from historical contexts marked by legal oppression and societal injustice, reflecting a deep-seated desire for reform. In Ireland, the musical call for independence and freedom from British colonial rule was a direct challenge to the laws and governance that enforced systemic oppression. Irish traditional music encapsulated the spirit of resistance, rallying citizens to advocate for their rights and celebrate their cultural heritage amidst legal constraints. Similarly, American punk rock emerged as a sonic rebellion against established norms, criticizing governmental policies and social injustices. The raw, unfiltered lyrics often attack the status quo, challenging legal frameworks that perpetuate inequality, discrimination, and government corruption.

Moreover, the influence of law can be seen in how both music scenes have shaped and been shaped by the cultural legal landscape. The rise of both genres during periods of political unrest highlights the role of law as both a barrier and a catalyst for change. Through their art, these musicians not only critique existing legal systems but also inspire collective movements that seek to replace oppressive laws with more equitable practices. Thus, the interaction between music, law, and social change emphasizes the power of artistic expression as a formidable tool for resistance and transformation.

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